



Hindustan Times

Qatar, US see progress in talks to end Iran war

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DUBAI/WASHINGTON: Qatar said on Tuesday mediators were making progress in efforts to end the US-Iran war, driving oil prices lower, although Tehran has denied President Donald Trump's assertion that talks are already under way.
Benchmark Brent crude fell more than 4% after the comments from Qatar, extending Monday's steep losses on hopes that an arrangement could soon be reached to restore traffic through the blockaded Strait of Hormuz.

continued on →10

13 Indians rescued as vessel sinks after attack off coast of Yemen

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: Thirteen Indian seafarers were rescued from an Indian-flagged vessel that sank after an attack off the coast of Yemen on Tuesday, with the government condemning the incident and reiterating its call to end the targeting of commercial shipping. Shipping minister Sarbananda Sonowal said on social

media that the cargo vessel MSV Faize Noore Oliya sank after being hit by "a projectile" near Yemeni waters. However, Yemen's government-aligned National Resistance Forces said the vessel was attacked by "an explosives-laden boat" off the country's western coast.
"We condemn the attack on the Indian-flagged commercial vessel, MSV Faize Noore Oliya, that sank in the Red Sea, off the

continued on →10

COMPLAINT AGAINST GIRL FOR REMARKS ON PM WITHDRAWN

NEW DELHI: The complainant in the case against a 15-year-old girl over her remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the CJP protest has withdrawn the complaint, saying that she no longer wished to pursue it as the teenager had apologised and the PM had forgiven her. Supreme Court lawyer Smriti Singh, who filed the complaint, said, "I had also posted a video saying that if the girls apologised, I would withdraw my complaint." →P5

CRPF JAWAN SHOOT DEAD 2 COLLEAGUES, KILLS SELF IN ASSAM

Biswa Kalyan Purkayastha
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SILCHAR: A Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) officer on Tuesday allegedly shot dead two of his colleagues and injured another in the firing before dying by suicide at the force's 34 Battalion camp in Katimari in Assam's Nagaon district, police said. The motive behind the incident is yet to be ascertained, they said. →P6

HEATWAVES NOW A NATURAL CALAMITY IN NDRF PROTOCOL

NEW DELHI: Heatwave and lightning have been included in the list of notified natural calamities under the operational guidelines for the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF) and National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF), the Union home ministry informed the Lok Sabha on Tuesday, adding that at least 20 heat stroke deaths have been reported in the country between March 1 and July 26 this year. →P8

MADHYA PRADESH AIR AMBULANCES SERVED 159 PEOPLE, 32 HAD BJP LINKS

Shruti Tomar
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BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh's PM (Prime Minister) Shri Air Ambulance Service launched in May 2024 has benefited 159 patients; 32 of them are either leaders of the Bharatiya Janata Party or their relatives or friends.
Of the 159, only 13 have paid for the service – those without an Ayushman card and being flown to a hospital outside the state have to pay for it according to the contours of the scheme – including a BJP leader and his relatives/friends.
The scheme comes under the health department and health minister Rajendra Shukla said people haven't paid for the service.

continued on →2

25 US states challenge Trump's Sec 301 tariffs

Shashank Mattoo
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WASHINGTON: Twenty-five US states have launched a legal challenge against President Donald Trump's effort to impose tariffs on 60 global economies – including India – for not acting against forced labour practices.

The coalition of states led by the Democratic party argued that Trump's effort to levy 10% or 12.5% tariffs on 60 countries under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 marked a sweeping and unlawful attempt by the president to levy tariffs on global economies despite the failure of two of his previ-

ous efforts, which courts struck down.
"For more than a year-and-a-half, the president has unilaterally imposed tariffs without legal authority to do so. These tariffs have been sweeping and broad, encompassing virtually all imported products from scores of countries," notes the lawsuit, which was filed on Monday with the New York-based Court of International Trade.
In their lawsuit, the states argue the Trump administration was using the Section 301 tariffs to reconstruct the earlier tariff regimes. Trump's global reciprocal tariffs – which were first announced in April 2025 – were struck down by the US Supreme Court in February this year. →P3



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NUMBER THEORY

Refocusing mid-day meals: What children really need

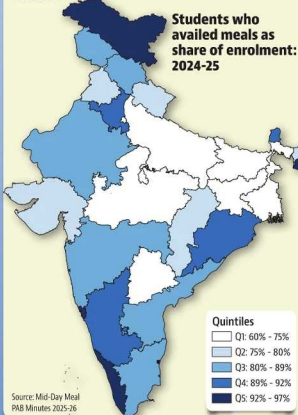
By Dipa Sinha and Bhargav BS

Over the last week, government school students in Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Bihar came out in protest, asking for better facilities. In addition to poor infrastructure and shortage of teachers, mid-day meals (MDM) are an important aspect of government school education in India. Following Supreme Court orders in 2001, hot cooked meals for children up to Class 8 across government and aided schools were expanded to the entire country. The MDM is a legal entitlement under the National Food Security Act (NFSA). Evidence shows that it protects against hunger, boosts enrolment and attendance, provides relief to mothers and improves nutritional outcomes. Over 110 million children across 12 million schools are covered under the scheme, providing employment to 2.5 million cooks and helpers, mostly women. MDM however, does not get enough public attention, and concerns related to implementation and quality remain. It is in the news only when there is a controversy over serving eggs or when cases of food poisoning occur. MDM can be expanded creatively to address the continuing burden of malnutrition, poor dietary diversity and high anaemia among children. A proposal costing ₹4,000 crore to introduce breakfast in MDM by the education ministry, as recommended by parliamentary panels and the new national education policy, NEP, was rejected by the finance ministry a few years back. The state governments of Assam, Gujarat, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Telangana have started providing breakfast on their own. With increasing enrolment in secondary and senior secondary classes, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Lakshadweep and Puducherry have also extended beyond Class 8. Expanding such initiatives nationally can have lasting benefits at a low cost. Here is a brief overview of what can be done to make MDM more effective.



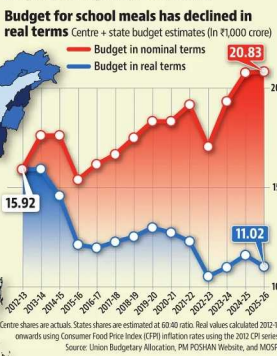
1 Universal on paper, but MDM coverage varies across states

While MDM is a universal scheme covering all children in eligible schools, nationally only 76.2% of enrolled children are being served. The coverage is uneven across states, with Goa having the highest coverage of 97% and Bihar the lowest with 60%. What explains this large variation? A thorough evaluation is required, but anecdotal evidence suggests that this gap could be due to a combination of inflated enrolment figures and some better-off children opting out of the scheme because of quality concerns.



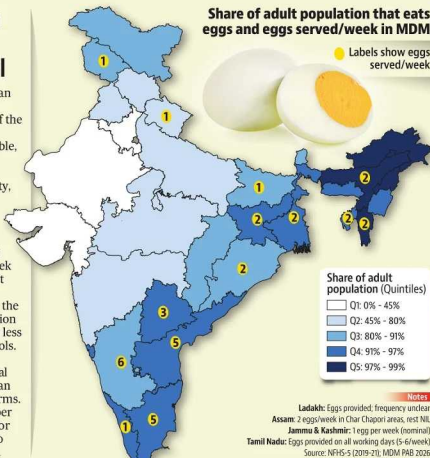
2 MDM also has a funds problem

One of the reasons for quality concerns regarding MDM is that the scheme is under-funded. This is despite the fact that MDM is one of the rare schemes where the principle of inflation-indexing is built in. Reasons are manifold. The base costs have not been revised since 2009. The cost-sharing norms were revised in 2015, reducing the contribution of the union government from 75% to 60% of the cooking costs. Estimating allocations by states (at 40% of central allocations) and then doing an inflation adjustment using Consumer Food Price Index, one can see a decline of 30% in real MDM allocations between 2012-13 and 2025-26. With increasing GDP and growing recognition of the nutritional challenge, we should be giving greater priority to the scheme; what we see is lower real allocations, which affect the quality and regularity of the scheme.



3 The debate on eggs is more fiscal than cultural

Introducing eggs in the meal is an effective way of improving nutritional quality and appeal of the scheme. Eggs are a complete protein source, highly bioavailable, cost-effective, and logistically feasible. Barring religious opposition from a small minority, the bigger constraint is cost. While the richer southern states now provide 4-6 eggs a week in their school meals, the poorer states such as Bihar and Jharkhand give only 1 or 2 a week (Figure 3). Over 80% of the adult population in most states is non-vegetarian. Further, across the country, the vegetarian population is also typically upper caste and less likely to be in government schools. Rather than debate cultural objections, a red herring, the real constraint is the finances that can be addressed by raising cost norms. Currently, the cost is about ₹6 per egg. We can surely afford that for the children of this country who continue to be undernourished.





Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

'ANY MLA FREE TO QUIT': K'TAKA CM AMID TALK OF RIFT

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BENGALURU: Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar on Tuesday issued a warning to MLAs threatening to resign after being overlooked in the cabinet expansion, saying if they resign, it will be accepted "within a few minutes". "When I was denied a ministerial berth during the tenures of Dharam Singh and Siddaramaiah, I could have resigned too... One needs to have patience," he said. →P5

COP HURT AS CLASH ERUPTS BETWEEN KANWARIYAS IN U.P.

MEERUT: An Uttar Pradesh Police constable was injured when a group of Kanwariyas allegedly assaulted him as he tried to stop a clash between two groups of devotees participating in the Kanwar Yatra in Meerut in the early hours of Tuesday, police said. Some Kanwariyas received minor injuries, with videos of the clash going viral on social media. →P5

META GLOBAL EXECS TO MEET MEITY AS COMPLAINTS MOUNT

Sejal Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Senior global executives from Meta will meet Meity officials on August 5-6 after the temporary takedown of a video of PM Narendra Modi. Meity secretary S Krishnan said the talks will also cover non-compliance with Indian laws, CSAM and synthetically generated content safeguards for verified accounts. →P5

SC tightens rules to curb digital arrests, RBI to draw up SOP

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday stepped up its oversight of the country's battle against the growing menace of "digital arrest" scams, issuing a fresh set of nationwide directions aimed at plugging systemic gaps in cyber fraud investigations, speeding up the restoration of victims' money and strengthening preventive mechanisms. Among its key directions, the court asked the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to frame within four weeks a standard operating procedure (SOP) for dealing with mule bank accounts used to launder proceeds of cyber fraud, directed all states to operationalise cyber fraud grievance redressal and money restoration systems, called for the adoption of the e-Zero FIR mechanism across the country, and asked the Centre to examine a shared liability and victim compensation framework for victims of digital arrest scams.

The directions were passed by continued on →10

morestories

NEET CBT shift hinges on Niekani panel call: Govt →P2
HP: SC bars wetland mining without Centre's nod →P6
Solid waste mgmt: SC seeks compensation guidelines →P9

What top court ordered

Reserve Bank of India to frame within four weeks an SOP to deal with mule bank accounts used to launder proceeds of cyber fraud.
All states to operationalise cyber fraud grievance redressal and money restoration systems.
E-Zero FIR mechanism to be adopted across the country.
Centre to examine a shared liability and victim compensation framework for victims of digital arrest scams.
IDC to review CBI probe norms, including lowering the ₹10cr threshold and aggregating scams by organised networks.
Meity, DoI and IAC to study time-based restrictions/warnings on long audio and video calls used in digital arrest scams.
Banks and intermediaries to develop stronger technological safeguards, aid investigations and recover stolen money.

TOP COURT PROPOSES NO FUEL FOR VEHICLES WITHOUT INSURANCE

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Centre and the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India to evolve a pilot project under which uninsured vehicles could be denied fuel at pumps, while also ordering a technology-driven enforcement mechanism to identify and penalise such vehicles. "The object behind mandatory insurance under the Motor Vehicles Act is not just that victims of road accidents are compensated, it is also that they are not drawn into prolonged litigation," the court noted. →P6

NEET-UG PAPER LEAK ACCUSED VOLUNTEER FOR LIE DETECTOR TEST

A fast-track court hearing the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case on Tuesday sought the Central Bureau of Investigation's response on a plea filed by three accused seeking permission to voluntarily undergo a lie detector test and brain mapping examination in order to "assist" the agency in its investigation. The plea stated, "The applicants have consistently maintained their innocence from the inception of the investigation and continue to assert that they have neither committed nor participated in the offences alleged against them." →P5

Stalin Jr held, released after day-long drama

S Vijay Karthik and Ayesha Arvind
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CHENNAI/BENGALURU: Leader of the Opposition in Tamil Nadu Udhayanidhi Stalin was arrested by the police for over 10 hours, taken from Chennai to Thanjavur and booked for insulting the modesty of a woman, obscenity and criminal intimidation, among others, over an obscene remark apparently aimed at actor Trisha Krishnan a day before.

In a day packed with high drama, Udhayanidhi was arrested from his residence in Chennai at 10am and taken to Thanjavur, where he had made the controversial comment at a rally on Monday. The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) hit



TN Opposition leader Udhayanidhi Stalin in police custody. →P1

the streets and approached the Madras high court, where the state government clarified that Udhayanidhi would be released "today itself".

In the evening, Udhayanidhi was taken to the Sengipatti police station after huge crowds

gathered in Thanjavur – roughly 35km from state capital Chennai, he was quizzed for more than an hour.

At around 8pm, he was released on station bail, and returned to Chennai around midnight. continued on →10

2 FIREMEN DIE IN G NOIDA AS WALL FALLS DURING POST-RESCUE OP

Arun Singh
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GREATER NOIDA: Two firefighters were killed and three others injured after a wall collapsed on them during a firefighting operation at an electronic chip manufacturing factory in Greater Noida on Tuesday, officials said. The incident prompted authorities to order a structural audit of the building, officials said. The fire broke out at around 3am at a two-storey manufacturing unit in Udyog Kendra-2, Ecotech-3, officials said. The blaze was largely contained in two hours. "At around 5am, while cooling operations were underway, a first-floor wall along with an iron beam suddenly collapsed onto a team of firefighters positioned beside a fire tender," a fire official said.

DON'T AIR HASINA PRESSER: B'DESH TO MEDIA; INDIA DISTANCES ITSELF

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: The Indian government on Tuesday distanced itself from former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina's plans to address a virtual news conference on August 5, saying it has no involvement in the event being organised by a private entity and does not endorse views that may be expressed at the forum. Bangladesh authorities have warned the country's media not to carry Hasina's comments and statements, referring to a ban imposed by the International Crimes Tribunal. →P7

{ DGCA INITIATES PROBE }

AI jet from Phuket to Delhi drops 300ft amid turbulence, 17 injured

Neha LM Tripathi
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NEW DELHI: An Air India flight from Phuket to Delhi encountered severe turbulence on Tuesday, causing a sudden loss of altitude that left 17 people injured, including 13 passengers and four cabin crew members.

The flight was carrying 137 passengers and eight crew members. It landed safely at Delhi's IGI Airport at 11am. An official familiar with the development said the pilot-in-command alerted air traffic control at 10.27am before



Injured passengers being taken for treatment in Delhi. →P1



declaring a "PAN PAN" urgency signal at 10.46am. Another official said the pilot reported injuries to those onboard following a sudden drop of approximately 300 feet in altitude. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation has initiated a probe into the incident. →P5



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MY INDIA | J KHAND EXAM PROTEST

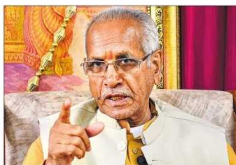
Awaiting CID report to take action: Soren



Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren assured protesting job aspirants that his government was sensitive to their concerns and that it was awaiting the Crime Investigation Department's report into the alleged irregularities in recruitment exams before taking further action. The statement came amid the aspirants' ongoing protest in Ranchi over alleged irregularities in exams conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC), among others. "I am repeating that this government has its eyes and ears at the right place," he said. "We are waiting for the probe report. Once we have the findings, we will act accordingly and inform the students and the state about the resulting decisions."

MY INDIA | AYODHYA DONATION ROW

Rai makes 1st public appearance since row



Former Ram Janmabhoomi Trust general secretary Tejendra Rai on Tuesday visited the Tapasvi Chhawani temple in Ayodhya, marking his first public appearance outside the trust premises since allegations of embezzlement of Ram temple donations surfaced two months ago. Since the row erupted, Rai remained largely confined to the Kshetra Bhawan, a 3-story building located near the temple complex. Rai was accorded a ceremonial welcome by Tapasvi Chhawani chief priest Paramhansa Acharya. The two held a closed-door meeting, though no details of the discussion were disclosed.

MY INDIA | HC LAPSE COST MAN TO MORE YRS IN JAIL

SC acquits murder convict jailed for 22 years, faults HC



The Supreme Court on Tuesday acquitted a man who spent 22 years behind bars in a triple murder case, expressing shock that a procedural lapse by the Orissa high court had kept him in prison for an additional decade. A bench of Justice JB Pardiwala and Vinod Chandran acquitted Ajay Jani, who was convicted of murder, holding that the evidence against him was unreliable. The top court also faulted the HC for refusing to condone the delay in filing his jail appeal, saying its insistence on a technical ground had cost Jani an additional decade of his life in prison. The court directed the district administration and legal services authority to help rehabilitate and resettle Jani.

MY INDIA | LOSS IN BANKIPUR

Modi meets Nitish after bypoll setback



Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday met JD(U) chief and RS MP Nitish Kumar, a day after the BJP lost the Bankipur assembly seat, its stronghold in Bihar, in the first electoral contest since Kumar stepped down as chief minister. "The meeting was about issues related to the development of Bihar. Former CM discussed some issues that needed attention and sought support for the state," said a person privy to the meeting. The person said "some political issues" were discussed but declined to comment on whether the bypoll results were specifically addressed by the two leaders.

BUSINESS | WIDE RETAIL NETWORK

Apple's sales in India passed \$10bn last FY



Apple exceeded \$10 billion in annual sales in India for the first time last fiscal year, underscoring surging demand for its pricey devices in a market where it's steadily ramping up its retail network. Revenue grew at double-digit percentage rate in the 12 months from March from about \$9 billion a year earlier, according to a person familiar with the matter, who asked not to be identified as the information is private. Apple's iPhones accounted for a significant majority of the sales, while demand for iPads and MacBooks also rose, the person said. The previously unreported figures in the world's most populous country are a boon for Apple's efforts to find new growth markets.

FROM PAGE 1

AIR AMBULANCES

vice because the government sometimes pays on humanitarian grounds. The service is provided by Fly-a, a private company that offers on-demand custom flight solutions. It handles operations via a 24-hour non-scheduled facility at the Bhopal Airport State Hangar.

The company's director corporate affairs, Monika Tiwari, said, "We own 12 aircrafts and two of them – a helicopter and a six-seater plane – are reserved for air ambulance services. We get approval from the health department, which checks whether the beneficiary is an Ayushman cardholder or not. We airlift non-Ayushman cardholders only upon reference from the CMJ officer or as special cases involving lives. They are trying to save lives. Until May, we were getting approvals offline, but now we are getting them online. We are providing quick service to every patient."

In all, the state has spent ₹36 crore on the service till July 3, according to commissioner of health department S Dhanraj.

HT has reviewed documents on the scheme and spoken to 119 of the 150 beneficiaries. At least 44% of the beneficiaries (70) were from the Rewa division – Rewa, Sidhi, Singrauli, Mau-ganj, Satna and Mahara districts – the home turf of health minister Rajendra Singh. "I am proud that most of the beneficiaries are from my region," he said.

The 13 who paid for the service included BJP leader Ram Sajjan Shukla and businessmen from Indore, Bhopal, Ujjain, Rewa and Jabalpur; all paid ₹5-10 lakh each. Individuals affected by road accidents, industrial mishaps, or natural disasters can be flown to government or private hospitals within and outside the state for free, according to the scheme.

"Ayushman card holders are eligible for free transportation to government and Ayushman-affiliated hospitals, regardless of the location. For those who do not possess an Ayushman card, the service provides free transport to government hospitals only within the state, while transport to medical facilities outside the state is available at contracted rates," read the service guidelines.

The service requires a recommendation of the district medical health officer. The contracted rate is ₹2.35 lakh per hour for a helicopter and ₹3.90 lakh per hour for a six-seater air ambulance. Of the 119 beneficiaries, 95 were airlifted within the state; 55 were taken to government hospitals – eight to the state government hospital and 47 to AIIMS Bhopal – and 40 were shifted to private hospitals.

Of the 64 people flown to other states, 31 were non-Ayushman cardholders, and 11 did not respond on whether they had Ayushman cards. Of the 31, only seven paid for the service, while seven others are special accident cases. Beneficiaries, who were flown outside the state and were required to pay, said nobody asked for money.

Former minister and MLA Gaurishankar Bisen said, "I felt pain in my chest so I was airlifted to Medanta hospital in Gurugram. No money was demanded from me. So I didn't pay anything. The BJP MLA from Garhwa Chandra Singh said, "My son was ill and the government made arrangements for an airlifting him to Ahmedabad. No money was asked for any of them."

Suneet Makin, son of petrol pump owner and businessman Rakendra Kumar Makin from Satna, gave the same reason for not holding a card. "My father was admitted to a hospital in Rewa. Health minister Shukla helped us in airlifting him to Delhi for a problem in the heart valve," he said. Chhannayy Tripathi, whose friend was flown to a private hos-

In full flight

159 Patients served by MP air ambulances

32 Are either BJP leaders or their friends or relatives

13 Have paid for the service, including one BJP leader

₹2.35/lhr for a helicopter

₹3.90/lhr for a six-seater air ambulance

Who can use the service? People affected by road accidents, industrial mishaps, or natural disasters can be flown to govt or private hospitals within and outside the state for free. Those without an Ayushman card and being flown outside the state have to pay for it.

pital in Bhopal from Rewa, said, "The service was provided free of cost on the recommendation of chief minister (Mohan Yadav) as I am his guru (teacher)."

HT has traced three individuals – businessman Madhu Wadhvani of Rewa, Ramesh Gupta from Rewa, and former MP Ram Vilas Das Yadav – were never airlifted but the company was paid for the trips.

Health minister Shukla explained the money, Jauges a fixed amount and once it is booked, the charges are applied whether the service is used or not.

Wadhvani and Yadav's families said they did before being airlifted, while Gupta's family refused transfer after seeing the condition of the plane, the family said. Tripathi also complained of the poor condition. "The oxygen cylinder was unhooked (when it was not in use) and most of the equipment was rusted. Nobody was ready to free, according to the scheme."

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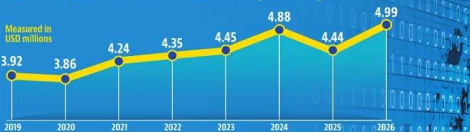
IBM REPORT

India's breach bill soars in face of AI

IBM's Cost of a Data Breach Report puts the average cost of a data breach for an Indian firm at an all-time high, driven by attacks now being generated by AI. – By VISHAL MATHUR

WHAT IT COSTS

India's average total organisational cost of a breach has risen 15.9% over the year to \$2.79 million (₹255 million). That is about 56% of the global average of \$4.99 million.



26% of malicious breaches in India involved AI-generated malicious code

THE AI TURN

Globally, AI-generated attacks are up 56%. Healthcare, financial services, industry and technology firms bear the brunt. IBM's framing is that attackers are not only using AI as a tool but are going after the AI models and applications organisations now run: the costliest incidents involving an organisation's AI model or applications were inversion and prompt injection attacks, with model inversion averaging \$6 million.

WHERE THE GAPS ARE

Of the organisations hit by an attack, 53% did not have data encrypted at rest or in transit at the time of the breach. Credentials, identities and data were the primary targets. Recorded breaches involved between 2,590 and 115,380 compromised records.

ON DEFENCE

IBM says AI used defensively does not fully isolate an organisation but contains the spread and speeds up response, including isolating critical infrastructure.

NEET SHIFT TO CBT WILL HINGE ON NILEKANI PANEL'S CALL: CENTRE TO SC

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NEW DELHI: The Centre told the Supreme Court on Tuesday that any decision to move NEET-UG from pen-and-paper to computer-based testing will await the recommendations of a high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani.

"In respect of NEET-UG, the migration from the Pen-and-Paper mode to Computer-Based mode, whether in a single-stage or a two-stage examination on the pattern of the Joint Entrance Examination (Mains and Advanced), is presently under active consideration by all stakeholders," the Centre said in an affidavit filed by the Department of Higher Education.

"The Union of India respectfully submits that the final approach to be adopted after considering and with the benefit of the recommendations of the High-Powered Task Force under the chairmanship of Nandan Nilekani."

The affidavit comes ahead of the August 6 hearing of pleas filed by the Federation of All India Medical Association and the United Doctors Front, among others.

Former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan had announced on May 15 that the examination would shift to computer-based mode from next year, and NTA officials had said they were targeting a tenfold expansion of anti-ragging with the same goal for medical examinations and natural disasters.

Shukla said some business persons have also benefited. He added that local private representatives provided this service on humanitarian grounds to small business owners and other non-Ayushman cardholders. "Later, all these cases got behind the approval of many paid for the service,"

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CERN (SWITZERLAND): In the book *Angels and Demons* by American author Dan Brown, a physicist at CERN successfully creates a substantial amount of antimatter and traps it in a portable magnetic canister. This is soon by a rogue faction and since it can only remain stable for 24 hours, the story becomes a race against time to find the device before it wipes out the entire Vatican City.

Part of Brown's fiction became reality earlier this year when a lab at CERN successfully transported antimatter. Just a few months before the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) closed down for upgrades, CERN's Barion Antibaryon Symmetry Experiment (BASE) successfully trapped antimatter and ported it across their campus. Instead of a Stanley cup-sized canister like in Brown's imagination, the container weighed 1,000kg. The antimatter trapped – a mere 92 antiprotons – was about enough to self-annihilate a hundred atoms.

But even this little action is a major feat in particle physics and engineering. The reason is what makes antimatter such a villain favourite in fiction – it is very tricky to stabilise and contain. "The moment it gets in contact with ordinary matter, it annihilates and is transformed into energy," says Dr Christian Smorra, a physicist who leads the BASE-STEP team in the Antimatter Factory at CERN. He's the one who built the transportation canister.

The case of the missing antimatter

In current physics, scientists believe that for every fundamental matter particle in the universe, there exists a corresponding antimatter with the same mass but opposite charge. An antilepton for an electron, an antineutron for a hydrogen atom.

If we follow this Standard Model of particle physics, the Big Bang should have produced an equal amount of matter and antimatter. There should be more instances of antimatter around us – at the macro level (like planets or aliens made of antimatter) or atomic level. For a reason that we don't understand yet, the universe today is all matter and almost no antimatter. Where did the excess antimatter go?

The understanding of the asymmetry of matter and antimatter in the universe is called the Baryon Asymmetry Problem and that's what the team at BASE is trying to solve. "We need to investigate antimatter particles to check if the symmetry holds or if there is an aspect missing in our understanding of the fundamental interactions in Nature," says Dr Smorra.

The one thing we do know is that antimatter exists. Even humans, a humdrum banana produce antiparticles, but the moment the subatomic particles come in contact with air or the banana's potassium, it self-annihilates. It's a massive engineering hurdle to produce an antiparticle and harder still to keep them stable and trap them. "In a conventional ultra-high vacuum, let's say 10⁻⁹ mbar, which is one trillion times lower than atmospheric pressure, antiprotons can survive for about one second," says Dr Smorra. A trap to hold antiprotons requires at least 10 million times lower pressure than atmospheric pressure.

Producing antiparticles is so hard that CERN is the only lab in the world where humanity can produce, slow down and store antiparticles to study them. CERN fires high-energy protons into a metal cylinder made of iridium. The collision transforms into new matter and creates pairs of protons and antiprotons. Mag-

netron filter out the unwanted particles, a decelerator slows down the antiproton and CERN's Antimatter Factory stores these antiparticles in a storage ring, suspended in vacuum. "Antimatter can be lifted by a forklift and is designed to fit in a lorry. Called the BASE-STEP, the 1000kg contraption is small enough to get through ordinary laboratory doors. Most of the tonne of weightage comes from its massive superconducting magnets which weigh 600kg."

The trap uses cryogenic cooling with liquid helium to keep the superconductivity of the magnet. It also comes with a vacuum chamber, power reserves and an ability to absorb bumps on the road (upto 1 G-force of accelerations in all directions). That should be enough, says Dr Smorra, for European roads.

The aim is to transport antiparticles to other labs in Europe

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Why transporting antimatter is a big step

That's where Dr Smorra comes in. The physicist who did his PhD in penning traps wanted to create relatively smaller traps to transport antimatter. For six years he worked on the transportation idea, spending 2.5 million euros on personal and scientific instruments, finally achieving success in March 2026. The portable Penning trap he has developed can be lifted by a forklift and is designed to fit in a lorry. Called the BASE-STEP, the 1000kg contraption is small enough to get through ordinary laboratory doors. Most of the tonne of weightage comes from its massive superconducting magnets which weigh 600kg.

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How to trap antimatter in a canister



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INDIA ACCUSES PAK OF USING LETHAL FORCE AGAINST PROTESTERS IN POK

Rezaul Haskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday accused Pakistan of using lethal force, intimidation and repression against protesters in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), resulting in the death of 90 civilians, as it again urged the world community to hold Islamabad accountable for human rights violations and atrocities.

The remarks by external affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal at a regular media briefing came against the backdrop of Pakistani authorities holding elections in two constituencies in PoK to complete the second phase of polls to the local assembly.

Jaiswal, who was responding to a question on violence by Pakistani forces against the protesters and the elections to the assembly in PoK, described the electoral exercise as a "complete farce" and called the world community to focus on "vanton killings" out that at least 90 civilians had lost their lives in a continuing crackdown by Pakistan since June. Jaiswal responded to a separate question about members of the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Taiba accusing the government of involvement in the killing of the terrorist group's commanders by reiterating New Delhi's call for Islamabad to dismantle terrorist infrastructure on its soil.

so they can run experiments, said Dr Stefan Ulmer, a particle physicist and BASE spokesperson. "We want to transport antimatter to our dedicated precision laboratory at the Heinrich Heine University in Düsseldorf," he says.

The future of antimatter research

Though modern physics is built on the Standard Model, it's just 100 years old and remains an incomplete understanding of the subatomic world. There are still things we don't know, or can't account for. Perhaps there is new physics hidden deep in the subatomic world or in the dark recesses of the universe. Finding the answer would either upgrade our understanding of the universe or fundamentally alter it – both great research quests.

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Resignation a part of politics: CM says over legislators' threats

Arun Dev
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday issued a stern warning to disgruntled Congress legislators threatening to resign after being overlooked in the cabinet expansion, saying if they resign, it will be accepted "within a few minutes."

The remarks came a day after some Congress MLAs expressed displeasure and offered to resign after missing out on a ministerial berth following the long-awaited cabinet expansion that saw 19 ministers getting inducted. Notable among the disgruntled legislators were Indu M. A. Yashwantharaya Gowda V. Patil, who submitted his resignation from the assembly, and Belur Gopalakrishna, who also offered to step down after being overlooked.

"Resignations are a part of politics. No one can stop those who want to resign. If they want the party and a political future, they should stay. If there is a party, everything else follows," Shivakumar told reporters in Bengaluru. "When I was denied a ministerial berth during the tenures of Dharam Singh and Siddaramaiah, I could have resigned too. Didn't. Parameshwara (deputy CM) and I remain patient... One needs to have patience."

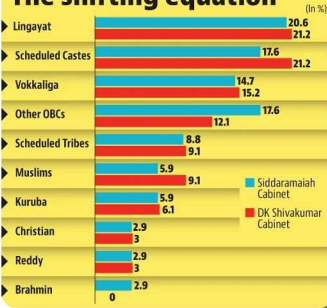
Asserting that the party is more important, Shivakumar said, "If anyone gives resignation, within a few minutes I'm going to accept."

Urging the disgruntled legislators to be patient and wait for their opportunity, the chief minister said posts in state-run boards and corporations will be filled up soon.

Those party men and legislators who were earlier appointed as members and heads of boards and corporations were told that their tenure will be for 2.5 years. It is already decided, I will first ask our workers to resign from the posts and fill up those posts after that. I will speak to MLAs as one by one," he added.

Shivakumar was sworn-in as the chief minister along with 13 ministers on June 3, following

The shifting equation



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— DK SHIVAKUMAR



Siddaramaiah's resignation as chief minister on May 28. The sanctioned strength of Karnataka's council of ministers is 34, including the CM. After the Monday expansion, the cabinet now has one vacant berth.

Shivakumar also dismissed any internal rift in the party after the swearing-in ceremony on Monday. Some party insiders claimed that the former CM was unhappy with the party high command ignoring several of his recommendations while finalising the cabinet expansion.

"There is a feeling among the (Siddaramaiah's) supporters that his views were not given the weight they deserved. That is what is being discussed inside the party," a senior party leader said, declining to be named.

Shivakumar, however, said Siddaramaiah was not dissatisfied with the cabinet exercise. Meanwhile, the BJP continued to attack the ruling Congress over the absence of women in the council of ministers.

"Priyanka Gandhi Vadra delivered long speeches under the slogan 'Main Ladki Hoon, Main Lad Sakti Hoon'. But where are the women in your own Congress Cabinet?" senior BJP leader and MLC T. Ravi said.

B'uru gets strongest cabinet presence ahead of GBA polls

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar has handed Bengaluru its strongest representation in the state cabinet ahead of upcoming elections to the Greater Bengaluru Authority.

Monday's cabinet expansion saw five MLAs representing Bengaluru Assembly constituencies inducted into the ministry. They include B.Z. Zameer Ahmed Khan (Chamrajpet), Rizwan Arshad (Shivajinagar), Ramalinga Reddy (BTM Layout), K.J. George (Sarvananagar) and Krishna Byre Gowda (Byattarayana).

A senior Congress leader said the cabinet exercise was designed with Bengaluru's electoral importance in mind.

"The GBA election is not just another local body election. It will decide the political narrative in Bengaluru. Ministers from across the city will now have

both administrative responsibility and political accountability. That was one of the considerations while finalising the cabinet," the leader said.

Another senior leader said the government wanted ministers who could directly oversee major infrastructure projects while simultaneously leading the party's campaign in their respective regions of the city.

The induction of Rizwan Arshad, a first time minister, and the return of Zameer Ahmed Khan were noted as key decisions. Together with senior ministers Ramalinga Reddy, K.J. George and Krishna Byre Gowda, the six ministers represent constituencies spread across much of Bengaluru.

Shivakumar has repeatedly described Bengaluru as the government's top priority. Since taking office, he has announced initiatives covering roads, mobility, storm water drains and urban governance



I WILL FOLLOW WHAT PARTY SAYS: SHANTHEGOWDA AFTER EXCLUSION

Agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Congress leader Gayathri Shanthegowda on Tuesday reacted to her exclusion from the revised cabinet list released a day earlier.

Speaking to ANI, Shanthegowda reaffirmed her loyalty to the party and said she would abide by its decision.

"I'm a loyal party worker. I don't want to react now. I've already said what I want to say from the grassroots level, and I will follow whatever the party says," she said.

Shanthegowda was notably the only woman leader whose name appeared in the first list of prospective ministers. However, in a swift turn of events, a second list was released just minutes later, which saw her name withdrawn.

When questioned about the last-minute inclusion and subsequent removal, the Congress leader declined to comment further.

"Further, I don't want to speak anything on this," she said.

Several senior Congress leaders, including HK Patil, Dinesh Gundu Rao, Lakshmi Hebbar, Shivnand Patil, RB Thimmapur, RV Deshpande, K Venkatesh, Krishnapada, Tanveer Sait, Appaji Nadagouda and Mahadevappa, were left out of the expanded ministry. Gundu Rao was among those who notably expressed their disappointment.

1 in 5 electors flagged before draft rolls: Data

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: With just four days left before the special intensive revision (SIR) ends in the state data released by the chief electoral officer on Tuesday showed that over one in every five voters in the state has been marked for possible deletion, placing Karnataka on course to record the country's largest draft stage electoral roll revision so far.

The data showed that 1,10,07,461 electors, or 20.04% of Karnataka's 55.4 million-strong electorate, had been classified under the 'Absent', 'Shifted', 'Duplicate', 'Dead' and 'Others' (ASDDO) category. The proportion overtakes the draft stage figures reported in Uttar Pradesh (19.08%) and Arunachal Pradesh (18.7%), while remaining well above Haryana (6.3%), Andhra Pradesh (10.78%) and West Bengal's 12% decline due to logical discrepancies.

The latest figures also indicate that the exercise is nearing completion. Election officials have digitised 5,34,50,000 enumeration forms, representing 99.84% of all electors. Only 87,254 forms remain pending, leaving little room for changes before the August 6 deadline.

The data shows Bengaluru



V Anbukumar

accounting for the largest share of voters marked under ASDDO. In BBMP South, 51.58% of electors have been placed in the category, the highest in the state, followed by BBMP Central (48.83%), BBMP North (47.83%) and Bengaluru Urban (45.42%). Every one of these districts has now completed 100% digitisation of enumeration forms.

Outside Bengaluru, the highest ASDDO proportions were recorded in Kalyanuragi (22.65%), Mysuru (20.59%), Raichur (18.69%), Ballari (18.15%) and Yadgir (18.01%), according to district-wise data.

The latest breakdown offers the clearest picture yet of why voters have been placed in the ASDDO category. Of the 11 million electors, 6.66 million (10.20%) have been classified as permanently shifted, making it by far the largest component. Another 1.63 million (2.65%) were marked as untraceable or

absent, while 16.28 lakh (2.94%) were classified as deceased. Officials also identified 6.86 lakh (1.24%) as already enrolled elsewhere and 5.02 lakh (0.93%) under other categories.

Chief electoral officer V Anbukumar said the ASDDO list had already been shared with recognised political parties and made available with Booth Level Officers for verification. He said electors who believe they have been wrongly classified can still have their enumeration forms restored through the BLO or the Electoral Registration Officer until August 8.

The Election Commission has also begun distributing 10 lakh Form 6 applications in the BBMP and Greater Bengaluru Authority areas to facilitate fresh voter registrations. Statewide, 12,09,885 applications for inclusion, correction, shifting and deletion have been received since June 16, including 3,66,788 Form 6 applications for new enrolment and 8,08,868 Form 8 applications seeking corrections.

As the digitisation exercise virtually concludes, the focus is now expected to shift from collecting enumeration forms to examining objections and claims from the revised electoral rolls move to the next stage.

BMTC conductor suspended over assault allegations

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: The BMTC on Tuesday suspended a conductor pending a departmental inquiry after a video purportedly showing him pushing a passenger out of a bus and assaulting him was shared widely, officials said.

The incident occurred on August 2, they said. In a statement, the Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation said that it has taken serious note of a video circulated on social media platforms, regarding the alleged misconduct of an on-duty conductor allegedly pushing a passenger out of the bus and physically assaulting him.

"As the video has received widespread circulation on social media and has raised public concern, BMTC has initiated immediate action," it said.

According to BMTC, without prejudice to the outcome of the inquiry, and as a preliminary measure, the conductor has been placed under suspension pending departmental inquiry. "A comprehensive departmental inquiry has been ordered to ascertain the facts of the incident," it said.



Basavaraj Horatti

CM CALLED ASKING ME TO RESIGN, CLAIMS COUNCIL CHAIRMAN
Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: State legislative council chairman Basavaraj Horatti on Tuesday claimed that chief minister DK Shivakumar had asked him to resign and phoned him requesting his resignation from the post, adding that he would decide after discussing the matter with BJP and JD(S) leaders.

He also asserted that electing the council chairman and assembly speaker is the prerogative of the House, not the high command of a political party.

This development followed a letter from the Congress high command to CM Shivakumar on Monday approving Monday's cabinet expansion. Shivakumar, an ally of the state legislative council and Ummahree for deputy chairperson. The party had also approved the names of G S Patil as the nominee for the speaker of the legislative assembly and A S Ponnanna for deputy speaker.

"The chief minister called me and requested that I resign and cooperate to prevent embarrassment, as the party has sent the name (for the new chairman)... Horatti told reporters. "This is beyond the first time I have seen a party declaring the chairperson of the legislative council. I'm not sure how they are doing this. I don't know if they are doing this for the first time. I have seen a party declaring the chairperson of the legislative council," he added. "To remove the chairman, ten members must give 14 days' advance notice, to move the no-confidence motion. Based on the discussion in the House the matter will be decided," said the senior JD(S) leader.

Annual flower show preparations



People walk past an installation set up as part of the annual flower show at the Lalbagh Botanical Garden in Bengaluru on Tuesday. The event is scheduled from August 6 to 17.

CM assigns drought-hit distts to ministers, orders timely action

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Chief minister D K Shivakumar has assigned districts to ministers and directed them to visit the areas immediately to assess the prevailing flood or drought situation and submit a report to the government.

While drought conditions persist in several parts of the state, heavy rainfall and flooding have affected a few other regions, disrupting normal life and causing damage to lives and property.

"In view of the heavy rainfall/flood/drought situation prevailing in the state, you, as a member of the Council of Ministers, are hereby requested to immediately visit the districts assigned to you. During the visit, personally inspect the situation in each taluk, assess the ground realities and submit a factual report without delay to the Deputy Chief Minister and the Minister for Revenue," Shivakumar said in a letter addressed to ministers on August 3.

CM ALSO ORDERED THE MINISTERS CONCERNED TO SUBMIT A REPORT ON THEIR DISTRICTS TO THE DYCM AS SOON AS POSSIBLE

Speaking to reporters on Tuesday, the CM said, "I have directed them to visit their respective districts from tomorrow itself and carry out site inspections. All ministers will be involved in the exercise from tomorrow. The districts assigned to the ministers are: G Parameshwara (Tumakuru), Raghubhatla (Chirururagi), Byrathi Suresh (Chikkaballapur), K H Muniyappa (Bengaluru Rural), Ramalinga Reddy (Kolar), H B Balakrishna (Bengaluru South), B Z Zameer Ahmed Khan (Vijayanagara), K J George (Chikkamagaluru), K M Shivalinga Gowda (Hassan), Madhu Bangarappa (Shivamogga), M B Patil (Vijayapura), Vijayanand Kashappanavar (Bagalkote) and Basavaraj Rayareddy (Gadag).

Others assigned districts are S S Mallikarjun (Davanagere), Rudrappa Laman (Haver), Satish Kirishidi (Belagavi), Santosh Lad (Dharwad), Laxman Sowdi (Uttara Kannada), Priyanka Kharge (Kalyanuragi), Ajay Dharam Singh (Raichur), Eshwar Khandre (Bidar), U T Khader (Dakshina Kannada and Udupi), P M Narendra Swamy (Kodagu), Yathindra Siddaramaiah (Mysuru), N Chelvarayaswamy (Mandya), K Puttanga Shetty (Channarayana), B Nagendra (Ballari), Sharan Prakash Patil (Yadgir), Shivraj Tanagadgi (Koppal) and Krishna Byre Gowda (Bengaluru Urban).

Vijayendra urges govt to release ₹100-crore special relief package for drought-hit farmers

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

TUMAKURU: State BJP president Vijayendra on Tuesday urged the state government to immediately release a ₹100-crore special relief package for farmers, highlighting severe rainfall deficits affecting more than 28 districts.

The BJP leader reiterated his demands for immediate drought relief, declaration of drought-hit areas, government payment of farmers' crop insurance premiums, and additional funds for drinking water arrangements and assured power supply to farmers.

Speaking to reporters after visiting drought-affected villages in Tumakuru district, Vijayendra said the government must take immediate steps to provide relief to distressed farmers without waiting for assistance from the Centre.

He said the BJP constituted seven study teams to assess the drought situation across Karnataka. The teams are visiting various districts, interacting with farmers, inspecting fields and documenting crop losses, he added.

Demanding that all 10 taluks of Tumakuru district be declared drought-hit, Vijayendra said farmers growing coconut, ragi, fruits and vegetables suffered major losses due to the rainfall deficit.



BY Vijayendra

Centre.

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Demanding that all 10 taluks of Tumakuru district be declared drought-hit, Vijayendra said farmers growing coconut, ragi, fruits and vegetables suffered major losses due to the rainfall deficit.

He also demanded that the state government bear the entire crop insurance premium payable by farmers, that farmers cultivators cannot afford their share.

The BJP leader requested an allocation of at least ₹50 lakh for every taluk in Tumakuru district to facilitate payment of crop insurance premiums.

"In several areas, sowing has not begun due to lack of rain, while in other places crops have failed to germinate," he said.

Vijayendra said, "Farmers face a serious financial crisis and the state government should fulfil its responsibility by releasing a special relief package of Rs 100 crore instead of only seeking assistance from the Centre. The process of seeking central assistance can continue, but protecting farmers should be the state's foremost responsibility," he said.

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[INDIA NANO 2026 CONFERENCE]

Time to put B'uru on world deep-tech map: CM

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Tuesday said the state is determined to lead the next wave of technological transformation by positioning Bengaluru as a global hub for deep technologies.

He said Karnataka is focusing on nanotechnology, artificial intelligence, semiconductor technology, and quantum technologies to achieve that goal.

Speaking after inaugurating Bengaluru India Nano 2026, Shivakumar said Karnataka's strong ecosystem of premier research institutions, startups, multinational R&D centres and universities gives it a unique advantage in emerging as a global destination for deep-tech innovation.

"Nanotechnology is no longer confined to research laboratories. It has become a foundational technology transforming



CM DK Shivakumar and state minister Priyanka Kharge at the inauguration session of the conference in Bengaluru on Tuesday.

healthcare, electronics, energy, agriculture, mobility, aerospace, defence and advanced manufacturing," he said.

The chief minister said the future would be shaped by the convergence of artificial intelligence, nanotechnology, biotechnology, quantum technologies, semiconductor technologies and advanced materials, adding that Karnataka intends to remain at the fore-

front of this technological revolution.

Highlighting Bengaluru's scientific legacy, Shivakumar recalled the historic meeting between Prime Minister Jawahar Lal Nehru and Tata and Swami Vivekananda aboard a ship travelling from Japan to the United States in 1923. Their discussions on scientific research and nation-building eventually led to the establishment of the Indian Institute of Science, he said.

He noted that the vision became a reality with the support of the erstwhile Kingdom of Mysore, where Maharaja Krishnaraja Wodeyar IV donated around 370 acres of land in Bengaluru for extended financial and infrastructural support for the institute.

"Today, nations are competing not merely for investments but for scientific leadership. Whoever leads in advanced materials, nanoelectronics, semiconductor technologies and AI-driven manufacturing will shape the global economy of the coming decades. Karnataka intends to be among those leaders," he said.

The chief minister said the state government is committed to creating an ecosystem where scientific ideas move rapidly from laboratories to industry and from research papers to commercial products through greater collaboration among academia, industry and startups.

He said nanotechnology has the potential to revolutionise healthcare through targeted drug delivery and precision medicine, transform agriculture through smart fertilisers and efficient water management, and enable cleaner energy, stronger infrastructure and sustainable manufacturing.

"The GCs of the future should file patents here, not merely close tickets here," he said, while urging academic institutions to place greater emphasis on patenting innovations and partnering with industry to bring real-world problems.

"Bengaluru has put India on the world IT map. It's now time to put it on the world deep-tech map," he added.

To jumps to 25 in rain-related incidents in Kerala, 4 missing

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The death toll in rain-related incidents in Kerala since August 1 jumped to 25 on Tuesday with four others missing, officials said.

Chief Minister V.D. Satheshan visited waterlogging-affected areas in Puthanmutha district near Arannulla and Ranni and interacted with affected people and temporary relief camps set up at government schools.

With IMD declaring red alert in at least six districts on Tuesday, the CM said all necessary arrangements for rescue and relief operations have been made.

"We have two IAF helicopters on standby, both for rescue as well as delivering essential supplies including food. NDRF teams are also present and will be deployed as and when necessary. Police Rapid Action Force (RAF) and Fire Force teams are also on the ground," he said.

The CM attributed the flash floods and numerous landslides in localised rainfall and cloudbursts.

"The gap between extreme rainfall being predicted on the radar and the time needed to shift people from such locations to relief camps is very small.



Severe soil erosion causes a riverbank collapse along the swollen Chaliyar river, threatening nearby houses, at Mundungara in Kerala's Malappuram district on Tuesday.

Forest officials have reported that numerous landslides and landslides have occurred deep within forests due to extreme rainfall. We are cautious of such extreme rainfall events especially in sensitive locations along the Western Ghats," he said.

He also said that following the floods in 2018 and 2019, major rivers including Pamba have been filled with large amounts of silt. "The absence of

proper cleanups in previous years have led to silt being accumulated in river basins. This has resulted in the river's carrying capacity being reduced. That's why floodwaters are not receding on time," he said.

As of Tuesday evening, 418 relief camps are operating across the state with 18,434 occupants. The most number of camps are in Puthanmutha (143), Kottayam (135) and Alappuzha (53).

While 52 houses have been fully damaged in the rains, 565 houses are partially damaged. The IMD has predicted heavy rains on Wednesday as well and declared code orange alert in nine districts.

Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheshan on Tuesday announced that a pilot project for a comprehensive disaster management resilience system, with an emphasis on early warnings, will be implemented in Puthanmutha district.

The CM announced the initiative while interacting with reporters after assessing the situation in Puthanmutha, a district that has been reeling under flash floods and severe water-logging since August 1. Major towns in the district such as Arannulla and Ranni have been experiencing extreme localised rainfall events, leading to hundreds of homes, shops and establishments being inundated by floodwaters. The pilot project of a comprehensive disaster management resilience system, which was announced in the budget, will be taken forward by the state government. As part of it, a clear warning system will be developed with the help of external expert agencies such as Cochin University of Science and Technology and Hume Centre," the CM

said. "There will be both manual rain gauges as well as those developed using Artificial Intelligence," added CM, stressing that the objective is clear: precision systems especially for extreme rainfall propelled by climate change.

Satheshan said that the challenge before authorities was the lack of adequate time to shift people from sensitive locations to relief camps where extreme rainfall and cloudbursts are predicted. The gap between such extreme events showing up on the radar and the time needed to shift people to safer locations is extremely small. Anything above 200 mm is extreme rainfall. Here, in Vadderikkar, the rainfall recorded was 340 mm," he said. The CM said that the administration would focus on removing excess silt from rivers like Pampa that have accumulated over years since the 2018 and 2019 floods. "We will remove the silt from rivers across the state and improve the carrying capacity of rivers," he said.

At least 25 people have been killed in rain-related incidents across Kerala since August 1 with four others reported missing. Over 18,000 persons, displaced from their homes, are currently housed in relief camps.

lighthouse A due whose name was writ on Cauvery waters



Ramu Manivannan

The crisis between Tamil Nadu and neighbouring Karnataka over the sharing of water from the Cauvery is not, by any means, a new one. Common people in both states have recently found themselves again riled against the clamour of heated, accusatory political posturing and an evasiveness that clouds consensus and derails any approach towards meaningful dialogue on the matter, which is a shame, really, considering that both state governments have remained quite consistent with their stances over the years.

"How can we hold back water?" observed Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar recently, when asked about the release of water from the Kabin dam, which reached Tamil Nadu early on Tuesday. Shivakumar's argument that the Mekedatu Dam Project is intended to act as a balancing reservoir to regulate the flow of Cauvery water while generating hydroelectric power that can pose a "permanent solution" to the problem of Cauvery water scarcity is at the centre of Karnataka's stance. It insists that the go-ahead for the project does not require any approval from Tamil Nadu's government, based on Clause XVII of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal (CWDT), 2007 and reaffirmed in the Supreme Court in 2018. The clause states that every riparian state could rightfully regulate waters within its borders so long as it stayed consistent with the CWDT award.

The Tamil Nadu government has maintained that the setup of any reservoir in an upper riparian state could curtail downstream flow and needed detailed scrutiny by the statutory bodies overseeing Cauvery water management, as well as the consent of all states sharing the Cauvery water system.

The Central Water Commission (CWC)'s decision to return the Karnataka government's detailed project report (DPR) on Mekedatu and seek a revised report that complies with the CWDT award and existing technical guidelines by CWC comes in this backdrop.

The Karnataka government picked a somewhat pendulous approach after the Cauvery Water Management Authority order to ensure a flow of 3,500 cusecs a day for 15 days, despite warnings that reservoir levels were under severe pressure from drought. After an unsuccessful bid to challenge the order, and the postponement of a planned meeting between the chief ministers of both states in Bengaluru (reportedly scheduled at Tamil Nadu CM V Jayalalitha's (Jayal) best), the state released 35,000 cusecs of water in the Kabin dam last Saturday, and scaled the output down to 10,000 cusecs

the following day.

Farmers and pro-Karnataka organisations have, meanwhile, intensified their grassroots struggle, with Shivakumar's call to withdraw a planned statewide bandh on August 13 likely to remain unheeded.

In keeping with the state's mood, Shivakumar maintained that the release was not meant specifically for Tamil Nadu, but because the reservoir reached full capacity after a recent wet spell in the Cauvery catchment and the release meant to ensure safety. As far as the state opposition is concerned, the BJP seems aligned with the government's vision for the Mekedatu project. It received bipartisan backing at the all-party meeting convened by Shivakumar on Sunday, and state BJP chief B.V. Vijayendra has reportedly urged Tamil Nadu's CM Jayalalitha to support the project. While the Cauvery debate is not the only issue behind the call for the August 13 bandh, it is the leaden keystone that keeps the state dispensation under pressure to maintain its headline position, regardless of whatever ecological calamities may afflict its downstream neighbour.

On the other hand, in Tamil Nadu, there is much more in political circles but little cohesion or bipartisan unity. While the chief opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) beat the state government in moving the top court to order Karnataka to comply with the CWA order, the DMK's stance regarding the issue seems to be that there is a need for the state government to consult all political parties, farmers' groups and other stakeholders before presenting its case through a clear political and legal strategy. While the government has reportedly sent out feelers to Karnataka, the Tamil Nadu Vetti Kuzhagam (TVK)-led dispensation and its allies have failed in reaching out to its challengers DMK and AIADMK to present a strong home front.

Negotiations may be out of the window for the moment. While Shivakumar's decision to postpone his meeting with Jayal does make sense considering the prevailing political climate in the state, the Tamil Nadu dispensation's awkward reference to the issue in a public meeting to call for a transparent and call an all-party meeting to seek political consensus defies political common sense.

To illustrate the problem, while the current rural development and water resources minister N. Anand has consistently avoided speaking on the issue with the media, when one considers the public call for TVK to come out in droves to celebrate the release of Vijay's film career swan song, *Jana Nayagan*, which spurred a frankly embarrassing spectacle of executive and legislative officials filling up the streets across the state, the reluctance here is even more difficult to understand.

To trace out an off-borrowed piece of wisdom that "water is nature's property" (most recently offered by none other than Shivakumar himself), and considering the role of the State as a mediator, the need of the hour is to step up high ground to police state and democratic water-sharing agreements that better fit our nature as a multi-ethnic and linguistic federal polity.

(Prof. Ramu Manivannan is a Political Scientist - Scholar-Activist in areas of education, human rights and sustainable development. He is currently the Director, Multiversity - Centre for Indigenous Knowledge Systems, Kurumbapalayam Village, Vellore District, Tamil Nadu)

[ANDHRA LIQUOR SCAM]

Key accused arrested after return from Dubai

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HYDERABAD: The special investigating team (SIT) of the Andhra Pradesh Police has arrested one of the key accused in connection with an alleged multi-thousand-crore liquor scam that took place during the previous YSR government. The Andhra Pradesh government, an official familiar with the matter said, adding that the accused had been absconding for the past two years.

According to an official, the accused, identified as Eshwar Kiran Kumar Reddy, was detained by immigration authorities at Hyderabad's Rajiv Gandhi International Airport on Monday night after returning to India from Dubai via Sri Lanka. He was subsequently handed over to the SIT for further investigation.

"He was produced before the local ACB court in Vijayawada on Tuesday and was remanded to 14-day judicial custody," the official said. He added that the accused was allegedly involved in creating shell companies to divert kickback money generated through the liquor distribution network.

KIRAN KUMAR REDDY LEFT FOR DUBAI IN NOV 2024 AFTER TDP-LED COALITION GOVT INTENSIFIED ITS PROBE INTO THE ALLEGED SCAM

People familiar with the matter said Kiran Kumar Reddy left for Dubai in November 2024 after the Telugu Desam Party (TDP)-led coalition government intensified its probe into the alleged scam. A Look Out Circular (LOC) was subsequently issued against him, and he is believed to have remained abroad while allegedly providing shelter to other accused.

So far, 12 people have been arrested in the case. Kiran Kumar Reddy recently moved to the Supreme Court seeking anticipatory bail. The top court on July 30 rejected his plea and directed him to surrender before the investigating authorities, he said. Asserting that economic revival depends on attracting

proper cleanups in previous years have led to silt being accumulated in river basins. This has resulted in the river's carrying capacity being reduced. That's why floodwaters are not receding on time," he said.

As of Tuesday evening, 418 relief camps are operating across the state with 18,434 occupants. The most number of camps are in Puthanmutha (143), Kottayam (135) and Alappuzha (53).

Originally from Tirupati, Kiran Kumar Reddy is the son of a police constable and graduated in engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kharagpur. The SIT alleged that after coming into contact with Kesrireddy, he became one of the principal operatives in the alleged scam and also brought other IIT graduates into the network. He is also under investigation in separate cases related to alleged liquor transportation irregularities by the ED.

Unravelling a progress report on the state's financial position at a press conference in the secretary's office, Naidu presented an assessment of Andhra Pradesh's economic condition after two years of the coalition government.

The chief minister alleged that the state had suffered two major setbacks over the past decade. The first was the bifurcation of the united state in 2014, which left Andhra Pradesh without a capital city and with only 46% of the combined state's resources despite having 58% of its population.

"The second setback occurred during the 2019-24 period, when institutions weakened industrial confidence declined, law and order deteriorated and the state's image suffered, discouraging private investment," he said.

Asserting that economic revival depends on attracting

Keralamin under fire over remarks on free bus rides for women

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala transport minister CP John drew criticism on Tuesday for remarks allegedly belittling women who avail free rides on KSRTC buses under the Priyadarshini scheme implemented by the UDF government in June.

Speaking at a state conference of the Kerala Bus Transport Association, a trade union body of private buses, in Palakkad on Monday, John said he was astonished by women's choices in public health, education and transport.

"I regret behaviour that I don't understand is that a woman, who can afford a bus ticket and scrambles into the Priyadarshini buses for free rides, chooses to send her children to private schools which charge high fees. There are vacant classrooms in government schools, but their kids are sent to private schools. But when it comes to healthcare, the same woman takes her father or husband to a government hospital and sleeps in the verandah. They don't want to go to private hospitals because they cannot afford the bills there," the minister said.

"We have understood the reality that women in the state don't have money in their hands.



CP John

That's why they are scrambling into crowded Priyadarshini buses," he added.

The minister's remarks disparaged women and their self-respect, John said he was referring only to the "state of poverty of women."

"The spirit of my speech was that around 35-40% people are experiencing deprivation due to financial distress. To overcome the drive the state is trying different things. My speech was aimed only at promoting the Priyadarshini scheme and to describe the distress faced by women who avail the scheme. I would never insult women," he said. Opposition leaders, however, rejected his explanation. Senior CPI(M) leader and MLA K. J. Joseph said the remarks reflected a feudal mindset.

CPI leader Annie Raja said, "His remarks amount to insulting women. The government continues to portray its schemes as generosity," she said.

AMARAVATI: CPWD FLOATS ₹1,000-CR HOUSING TENDER

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NEW DELHI: Nearly two months after the Union Cabinet approved the construction of government housing in Andhra Pradesh's new capital, the Central Public Works Department (CPWD) on Tuesday floated a ₹1,083.14 crore tender to build 1,504 General Pool Residential Accommodation (GPRA) units across Andhra Pradesh. The project is intended to provide housing for central government employees posted in the state's new capital and support the creation of permanent central government infrastructure there.

The project is to be completed in 28 months, including three months for planning and approvals and 25 months for construction.

The Union Cabinet, headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the GPRA project on June 10, describing it as the first General Pool Residential Accommodation project in Andhra Pradesh.

The project is intended to provide housing for central government employees posted in the state's new capital and support the creation of permanent central government infrastructure there.

CM Naidu says Andhra back on sustainable growth path after 2 yrs

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday claimed his administration had moved the state from "economic destruction" to a path of sustainable growth over the past two years through investments, infrastructure creation, fiscal discipline and technology-driven development.

Unveiling a progress report on the state's financial position at a press conference in the secretary's office, Naidu presented an assessment of Andhra Pradesh's economic condition after two years of the coalition government.

The chief minister alleged that the state had suffered two major setbacks over the past decade. The first was the bifurcation of the united state in 2014, which left Andhra Pradesh without a capital city and with only 46% of the combined state's resources despite having 58% of its population.

"The second setback occurred during the 2019-24 period, when institutions weakened industrial confidence declined, law and order deteriorated and the state's image suffered, discouraging private investment," he said.



N Chandrababu Naidu

private investment, Naidu said Andhra Pradesh's development strategy was centred on rebuilding investor confidence.

"Development generates income, and income generates welfare," he said, arguing that sustained economic growth, rather than debt-funded expenditure, was the only way to improve living standards.

According to Naidu, the government had introduced investor-friendly policies aimed at transforming Andhra Pradesh into a preferred investment destination. These include large-scale investments in data centres, information technology, artificial intelligence, ports, airports, steel, pharmaceuticals, logistics and advanced manufacturing. Naidu said the Visakhapatnam region was being developed as a major growth engine through investments in IT, AI, steel manufacturing, irrigation projects, ports and airport infrastructure.

2 WOMEN KILLED, 3 INJURED AFTER CAR OVERTURNS IN ANDHRA: POLICE

Agencies

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PALAMANER: Two women were killed and three others injured after a car travelling from Karnataka to Tirupati met with an accident near Ramapuram on the V Kota Express Highway in Palamaner, Chittoor district, police said on Tuesday.

According to police, one person died on the spot, while another woman succumbed to her injuries while undergoing treatment at a hospital.

The deceased have been identified as Gautami and Manasa, both residents of Tirupati.

Police said the family was returning to Tirupati from Karnataka when the accident took place. The husband of one of the deceased and two of their friends survived the crash but sustained serious injuries.

A preliminary investigation suggested that the car lost control following a tyre burst and overturned multiple times, leading to the casualties, police said. Following the incident, police reached the spot, shifted the injured persons for medical treatment, registered a case and initiated an investigation into the accident.

Former YSRCP MLA arrested in kidnapping and extortion case

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh police arrested former YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) lawmaker from Guntur (East) Shaik Mohd Basheer on Tuesday in the early hours of Tuesday in connection with an alleged kidnapping and extortion case arising from a business dispute in the tobacco trade, police said.

A team of police officials from Nuzvid went to Ahmedabad and arrested the former MLA, who, along with his son Mohd Basheer, was booked on charges of kidnapping, criminal intimidation and under provisions of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

"Basheer remains absconding, and efforts are on to trace him," a senior police official from Nuzvid police station said. According to police, Mustafa, who owns a tobacco warehouse in Guntur, had business dealings with Kadimi Suryachandram, a tobacco trader from Koyyalagudem in Eluru district, who procured tobacco from farmers and supplied it to Mustafa.

The relationship soured after Mustafa allegedly reduced cur-



Shaik Mohammed Mustafa

rent prices, prompting the tobacco trader to sell his tobacco to him and instead supply another company in Guntur.

Police said that on Saturday night, Suryachandram's son Abhil, along with driver Balaji and clerk G Durga Rao, was transporting tobacco bales from Koyyalagudem to Guntur when their vehicle was intercepted near Nuzvid by Basheer and several associates travelling in two cars.

The accused allegedly seized the tobacco trader and his son and abducted the three men over an alleged dispute regarding pending payments," the police official said, quoting Suryachandram's complaint.

When Suryachandram contacted Mustafa, the latter allegedly warned him that unless he came to Mustafa's tobacco warehouse in Guntur, Basheer cleared the outstanding dues, he

"would not see his son again."

Believing the victims were being held at Mustafa's tobacco warehouse in Pedakakani, Nuzvid, police coordinated with their counterparts in Guntur district.

In the early hours of Tuesday, the victims were brought to the Pedakakani police station along with some of the accused, who surrendered before the police. Mustafa and his son were released safely," police said.

Mustafa and his son, however, allegedly fled the spot. Following a search operation, police tracked down and arrested Mustafa in Gujarat, while Basheer continues to evade arrest.

YSRCP Guntur district president and former minister Ambati Rambabu accused the Chandrababu Naidu government of pursuing political vendetta by foisting criminal cases against the former MLA.

He told reporters that a routine business dispute involving an advance payment for a tobacco transaction had been deliberately converted into serious criminal offences solely to prove the state's case against Basheer from securing bail.

KERALA POLICE WARNS PUBLIC AGAINST 'CLICKFX'

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala police on Tuesday warned the public about a new cyber scam called "ClickFX", which tricks users by fake CAPTCHA verification pop-ups to gain access to their computers and steal sensitive data.

In an advisory, the police said cybercriminals were using malicious pop-ups to gain access to their computers and steal sensitive data. According to the police statement, victims are shown a fake dialogue box containing instructions that, if followed, allow attackers to compromise their systems.

The attackers can then steal online banking credentials, email accounts and passwords from the victims' web browsers, including those for social media platforms. They may lock users out of their accounts and demand a ransom to restore access. The verification pop-ups also stressed that no legitimate website asks users to open or execute PowerShell or Command prompt commands, download files or visit suspicious links. Part of CAPTCHA verification.

17 injured as Air India flight altitude due to turbulence

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NEW DELHI: An Air India flight from Phuket to Delhi encountered severe turbulence on Tuesday, causing a sudden loss of altitude that left 13 passengers and four cabin crew members with injuries—an incident that has prompted the aviation regulator to launch an investigation.

Flight AI2379, an Airbus A320neo registered as VT-EXO, was carrying 137 passengers and eight crew members. The aircraft landed safely at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport in hazy, ahead of its scheduled arrival time of 11:55am, according to the flight tracking website Flightradar24.

People aware of the matter said Delhi airport was alerted immediately after the crew reported the incident, following which medical teams were deployed to receive the passengers and crew upon landing.

An official familiar with the development said the pilot-in-command alerted air traffic control (ATC) at 10:27am before declaring a "PAN PAN" urgency signal at 10:46am. The pilot requested specialised doctors to treat potential spinal injuries and requested an ambulance immediately upon landing.

An official speaking on condition of anonymity said the pilot reported severe injuries to one cabin crew member, injuries to another crew member, and minor injuries to a few passengers following a sudden drop of approximately 300 feet in altitude.



(Left) Cracks appeared on the flight's roof after it experienced severe turbulence, a detached flap on an overhead storage bin lied on the floor. ANS/SUSANAGA/X

The incident occurred roughly 110 minutes into the 3-hour, 50-minute flight, when the plane is estimated to have been over 32,000 feet above sea level. The weather in the general region at the time would have been stormy owing to typical monsoon conditions.

Earlier in the day, the airline confirmed the aircraft experienced a brief turbulence-related event during cruise, resulting in a momentary change in altitude before landing safely in Delhi.

"The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has initiated a detailed investigation into the occurrence. The ministry of civil aviation and DGCA are closely monitoring the situation.



(Left) Cracks appeared on the flight's roof after it experienced severe turbulence, a detached flap on an overhead storage bin lied on the floor. ANS/SUSANAGA/X

Passenger safety remains the highest priority, and all necessary measures are being taken," a government statement said.

"The aircraft has been moved to the hangar and the Flight Data Recorder and Cockpit Voice Recorder have been secured for detailed examination," the government confirmed.

Immediately upon landing, medical teams attended to all passengers and crew as a precautionary measure. Eight passengers and four cabin crew members have been admitted to hospitals for detailed medical evaluation and treatment. The remaining passengers were provided the necessary assistance and support," the government added.

"As of 18:50 hrs on 4 August, five passengers have been discharged, while the remaining individuals continue to receive treatment and care. Air India teams remain at the hospitals and in close contact with those affected to provide all necessary assistance and support," an Air India spokesperson said later.

"Air India is fully cooperating with the investigation, and the aircraft manufacturer has also been notified," the spokesperson added. "The safety and well-being of our passengers and crew remain Air India's foremost priority. We will continue to support those affected and their families and will work closely with the relevant authorities throughout the course of the investigation."

Civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu visited Fortis Hospital, accompanied by secretary Samir Kumar Sinha, to inquire about the condition of the injured passengers and assure them of assistance. Senior officers of the ministry also visited Fortis and Medanta hospitals to coordinate medical care, the government said.

The daughter of an injured passenger told news agency ANI that her mother suffered a head injury. "I am from India. The aircraft seemed to be moving normally but suddenly the turbulence began. I saw my sister thrown up into the air from her seat. My mother was knocked on her head. My phone fell away. People sitting behind me suffered injuries. A male passenger had blood on his face,"

Modi, Nitish meet day after Bakkipur defeat

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday met former Bihar chief minister and JD(U) president Nitish Kumar, a day after the BJP failed to retain its stronghold of Bakkipur in the poll, the first election after Kumar stepped down as CM. The seat earlier held by BJP's national president Nitin Nabin has been wrested by Jan Suraj Party's Prashant Kishor.

According to people aware of the details, the agenda for the first meeting between the PM and Kumar, after he became a Rajya Sabha MP, was largely confined to "Bihar's development, the roadmap for the future of the state and the alliance."

The JD(U) is a key ally of the BJP led National Democratic Alliance and the two parties run a coalition government in Bihar. "The meeting was about issues related to the development of Bihar. The former CM discussed some issues that needed attention and sought support for the state... It was largely about development and infrastructure enhancement," said a person privy to the meeting of the two leaders.

The daughter of an injured passenger told news agency ANI that her mother suffered a head injury. "I am from India. The aircraft seemed to be moving normally but suddenly the turbulence began. I saw my sister thrown up into the air from her seat. My mother was knocked on her head. My phone fell away. People sitting behind me suffered injuries. A male passenger had blood on his face,"

While the PM's office put out a photograph of the meeting, Kumar who was accompanied by JD(U) working president and MP Sanjay Jha and Union minister



PM Narendra Modi with JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar. @PMODIN

ter Rajiv Ranjan Singh in a post on X said, "Today, I had the courtesy of a meeting with the Honourable Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji in his office chamber at Parliament House." The post, stating a BJP leader responding to a question on the implications of the bypoll for the alliance said, "Both the BJP and the JD(U) will assess the result of the bypoll although the Jan Suraj winning the seat has more grave implications for the Rashtriya Janata Dal whose candidate (Rekha Kumar) forfeited her security deposit (for failing to win at least one-sixth of the total votes polled)."

While the BJP on Monday attributed the loss to a raft of issues, the JD(U) for its part has been largely silent. On Tuesday, a JD(U) leader said the emergence of a new outfit in Bihar's poll dominated by caste will ring an alarm for the established parties particularly the BJP, which banks on a wider coalition of castes and does not have a stronghold in terms of electorate. He said the party will also have to "consider the acceptability" of CM Samrat Choudhary among the electorate and its own votebank.

AFTER DATIA LOSS, NAROTTAM SKIPS BJP REVIEW MEET

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BHOPAL: Senior Madhya Pradesh BJP leader and former home minister Narottam Mishra skipped a BJP review meeting on Tuesday convened to analyse the party's defeat in the Datia assembly bypoll, triggering speculation over his role in the electoral setback and his standing within the party.

The meeting, said people aware of the matter, was held at CM Mohan Yadav's residence in Bhopal a day after Congress candidate Ghanshyam Singh defeated BJP's Anshu Tiwari by 6,006 votes in the bypoll.

Mishra's absence drew attention as he was in Bhopal when the meeting took place. The BJP had made the Datia contest a prestige battle, deploying at least 12 ministers, including a deputy CM, six MPs and several senior leaders during the campaign.

A senior party leader, requesting anonymity, said, "The decision to not call Mishra, once considered the BJP's strongman in Datia, suggests his role is also under question, especially given the reactions of his supporters when he was denied a ticket."

Mishra declined to comment when contacted by HT. Khandewal avoided directly addressing Mishra's absence but announced the formation of a two-member committee to examine the reasons of defeat.

PB RESOLUTION SEEKS SUSPENSION OF E20 ROLLOUT

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CHANDIGARH: The Punjab assembly on Tuesday passed a resolution urging the Centre to review and suspend the mandatory rollout of E20 ethanol blended fuel for vehicles until all concerns are comprehensively addressed.

The Haryana government moved the resolution on a day party chief Arvind Kejriwal marched towards the Prime Minister's residence in the national capital with over 220,000 petitions against E20 petrol but was stopped by Delhi Police and later held a sit-in on Feroz Shah Road as part of the agitation against the blended fuel policy.

On the second day of the Monsoon session of the Punjab Assembly here, Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema moved the resolution and criticised the mandatory implementation of 20 per cent ethanol blending (E-20 petrol) from August 2026. Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Tuesday announced the Centre of forcing E20 fuel on people without any proper research, scientific study or consultation. "This is a matter of grave concern for every citizen of the country. E20 ethanol-blended petrol has been forced on our vehicles without any proper research, scientific study or consultation," he said in the House.

Soren assures job aspirants of action in exam 'irregularities'

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RANCHI: Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren on Tuesday said his government was serious about concerns raised by protesting job aspirants and that action would be taken after the special investigation team (SIT) of the state Criminal Investigation Department (CID) submits its probe report into alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations.

The statement—a first from Soren on the issue—came as job aspirants, who have been staging an indefinite sit-in at Jaijal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi since July 26, stepped up their agitation by demanding probe by central agencies into alleged irregularities in the recruitment examinations conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission.

"This government has its eyes and ears at the right place. I can't tear open my heart to show you how seriously we are looking at things... The SIT is working day and night. We are waiting for the investigation report. Once we have the findings, we will act accordingly and ensure justice to the state about the decisions," Soren told reporters.

When asked if a delegation would engage with the protesting students, the CM said every action required for their welfare would be taken. "Everything possible as



Hemant Soren

per constitutional norms would be done for them," he said.

CD has arrested 12 people so far in connection with the alleged irregularities in JPSC examinations, while the commission postponed the Combined Civil Services Mains Examination, originally scheduled for July 25 to 27, citing "unavoidable circumstances" amid mounting protests.

Meanwhile, former CM Raghubar Das urged Soren to hold direct talks with the agitating youths and consider their demand for a CBI probe. Das said he had written to the union minister appealing to him to engage with the students and initiate appropriate action.

"The students have not taken to the streets without reason. They are protesting against serious allegations of corruption and irregularities in recruitment examinations. The government should talk to them directly and ensure justice, including considering their demand for a CBI inquiry," Das told reporters in Jamshedpur.

POLICE USE WATER CANNONS TO STOP NSUI PATNA MARCH

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PATNA: Bihar Congress chief Rajesh Ram and National Students' Union of India (NSUI) chief Vinod Jakhar along with NSUI state president Jaishankar Prasad Singh (Suraj Yadav) and dozens of students were arrested by police on Tuesday while participating in the students' march towards the chief minister's residence, officials said.

The march, which began from Gandhi Maidan, was organised by the NSUI to highlight alleged police excesses against students during recent agitation over exam paper leaks. Purnea MP Pappu Yadav and members of other student organisations such as AISA, STI and AISF also participated in the march.

The police used water cannons to disperse the protesters. Rajesh Ram, NSUI leaders and some others were taken into custody, but were released later on Tuesday.

Sub-Divisional Police Officer Amarendra Kumar Jha said, "We have not detained anyone but only asked them to stop the march. We're summoned to appear before a competent authority for presenting their grievances."

Pappu Yadav

COURT SUMMONS PAPPU YADAV OVER PARL SKIT

HT Correspondent
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PRAVARGA: A Prayagraj court on Tuesday issued notice to Independent MP Rajesh Ranjan, alias Pappu Yadav, from Bihar's Prayagraj constituency, for failing to appear in court to face charges of a criminal complaint filed by a BJP functionary over a skit linked to the Ram temple donations.

The skit, in the Parliament complex on Friday, alleged that the BJP had hired a criminal to perform a skit linked to the Ram temple donation that BJP legal cell's Uttar Pradesh co-convenor Sushil Kumar Mishra. After hearing the matter, the court found a prima facie case and issued notice to the MP under relevant provisions of BNS.

"There will be a range of issues. We would like to understand from them as to why some of these things have not been working the way they are supposed to work and what are their challenges. After all, these are some of the world's leading technology companies and they should have technology to make this work," Krishnan said.

Meta's global executives and MeitY officials to meet today

Sejal Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Senior global executives from Meta, the parent company of Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, will meet officials from the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) on August 5 and 6 following a temporary take-down of a video posted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, a government official aware of the matter said on Tuesday.

MeitY summoned the tech giant after a Facebook reel by the PM addressing national-level protests over the National Eligibility cum Entrance test (NEET-UG) paper leak was removed from the platform for about five hours on July 28.

Speaking on the sidelines of an event in Delhi, MeitY secretary S Krishnan said the discussions will cover non-compliance with Indian laws, Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM), synthetically generated content, and safeguards for verified accounts,

Arun Dev

BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday said he was willing to discontinue Congress legislators threatening to resign after being overlooked in the cabinet expansion, saying if they resign, it will be accepted "within a few minutes."

The remarks came a day after some Congress MLAs expressed displeasure and offered to resign after missing out on the cabinet berth following the long-awaited cabinet expansion that saw 19 ministers getting inducted. After the Monday's expansion, the cabinet now has one vacant berth. Notable among the disgruntled legislators were Indu Mala Yashwanth and V. Prasad, who submitted their resignation from the assembly, and Belur Gopalakrishna, who also offered to step down after being overlooked.

"Resignation is a minister's politics. No one can stop those who want to resign. If they want the party and a political future, they should stay. If there is a party, everything else follows," Shivakumar told reporters in Bengaluru. "When I was denied a ministerial berth during the tenure of Dattatraya Singh and Siddaramaiah, I could have resigned too. Didn't G Parameshwara (deputy CM) and I remain



DK Shivakumar

patient?... One needs to have patience." Asserting that the party is more important, Shivakumar said, "If anyone gives resignation, within a few minutes I'm going to accept."

Urging the disgruntled legislators to be patient and wait for their opportunity, the CM said posts in state-run boards and corporations will be filled up soon. "Those party men and legislators who were earlier appointed as members and heads of boards and corporations were told that their tenure will be for 2.5 years. It is already decided. I will first ask our workers to resign from the posts and fill up those posts after, then I will speak to MLAs," he added.

Some party insiders claimed that the former CM was unhappy with the party high command ignoring several of his recommendations while finalising the cabinet. Shivakumar, however, said Siddaramaiah was not dissatisfied with the cabinet exercise.

COP INJURED IN MEERUT AFTER TWO KANWARIYA GROUPS CLASH

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MEERUT: An Uttar Pradesh Police constable was injured when a group of Kanwariyas allegedly assaulted him as he tried to stop a clash between two groups of devotees participating in the Kanwar Yatra in Meerut in the early hours of Tuesday. Some Kanwariyas received minor injuries, with videos of the clash going viral on social media.

The clash broke out around 3 am after a motorcycle carrying two Kanwariyas collided with a group of devotees returning from Haridwar with the Ganga water. The collision triggered an argument, which quickly escalated into a fight.

The constable, Dinesh Kumar, rushed to the spot. Police said Kanwariyas pushed and assaulted him. One of them allegedly hit Kumar on the head with a stick. Additional police forces were rushed to the spot and brought the situation under control. Inspector Suman Singh counselled both groups and warned them against repeating such behaviour during their journey to continue their journey. Police seized two scooters and one motorcycle found abandoned at the spot.

Videos of the incident circulated on social media prompted a group of Kanwariyas dragging two men out of a police jeep and assaulting them with sticks. They showed a policeman attempting to intervene as the two men are beaten and their clothes torn. One of them is seen trying to flee meaning he was being held before being chased.

Meerut SP Vinayak Gopal Bhone said alleged allegations that Kanwariyas were involved in assaulting anyone. Bhone said two groups clashed, and police rushed to the spot promptly, brought the situation under control.

AMID ROW, COPS SAY KARNI SENA PROTESTER DIED OF HEART ATTACK

JAIPUR: A protester died in Jaipur after a Karni Sena rally against the UGC Regulations 2026, with the death on Tuesday claiming that the police action during the demonstration led to his death, while police maintaining that the youth died of a heart attack.

The rally was held on Monday to press for a rollback of UGC Regulations 2026 and other demands concerning the community protesting during the protest and was taken to a private hospital before being referred to SMS Hospital, where he died.

At a press conference on Tuesday, police said the protester, a 35-year-old man, died of a heart attack. The police said the protester was taken to a private hospital before being referred to SMS Hospital, where he died.

Police officers, however, disputed the claims. DCP (West) Prashant Krnan said, "Devraj Gupta was designated to a room around 8 pm, hours after the protest ended and was diagnosed with a heart attack," mrc

{ 'SERIOUS MISCONDUCT' }

U'khand cop dismissed for joining CJP protest

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DEHRADUN: A constable posted in Pithoragarh who participated in a protest in Coimbatore against a Janata Party protest at Jantar Mantar in Delhi has been dismissed from service, officials said on Tuesday, adding that the constable's involvement in the protest was found guilty of "serious misconduct".

According to a statement issued by the Pithoragarh police, constable Sher Singh was removed from service with immediate effect following disciplinary proceedings initiated following his involvement in the Pithoragarh Police Act, 2007.

Pithoragarh SP Akshay Prasad Konde said departmental inquiry, examination of official records and other relevant facts found that the constable's conduct amounted to "serious misconduct" and violated provisions of the Uttaranchal Government Service Conduct Rules, 2002. "The action was taken to

uphold discipline within the police force and maintain public confidence in the organisation," he said.

The Uttaranchal Police follows a zero-tolerance policy towards indiscipline, misconduct and violation of service conduct rules. Any deviation from the prescribed standards of integrity, discipline and accountability will invite strict action in accordance with the law," the statement said.

Singh made headlines after he announced his resignation from the Uttaranchal Police while being on the stage at the protest site. Singh alleged that the question paper for entrance in Uttarakhand was available at grocery stores.

COMPLAINT AGAINST TEEN OVER REMARKS ON MODI DROPPED

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NOIDA: The complaint in the case against a 15-year-old girl over her abusive remarks against PM Narendra Modi at the CJP protest has been withdrawn, the complainant, saying she no longer wished to pursue it as the teenager had apologised and the PM had forgiven her.

Supreme Court lawyer Smriti Singh, who had lodged the complaint, said on Tuesday that the FIR was initially filed against eight girls, with the Noida teen being the first among them. She said the zero FIR was registered on July 29 based on a complaint lodged by her at the Expressway police station in Noida.

The case was registered under sections 352 (insult with intent to provoke breach of the peace), 353(i) (statements conveying to public mischief) and 356(i) (defamation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), she said. "That the FIR was registered against a girl in a land grabbing case in Haridwar last year,

Sejal Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Senior global executives from Meta, the parent company of Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, will meet officials from the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) on August 5 and 6 following a temporary take-down of a video posted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, a government official aware of the matter said on Tuesday.

MeitY summoned the tech giant after a Facebook reel by the PM addressing national-level protests over the National Eligibility cum Entrance test (NEET-UG) paper leak was removed from the platform for about five hours on July 28.

Speaking on the sidelines of an event in Delhi, MeitY secretary S Krishnan said the discussions will cover non-compliance with Indian laws, Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM), synthetically generated content, and safeguards for verified accounts,

Court seeks KBI reply for lie detector test of NEET leak accused

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NEW DELHI: A fast-track court hearing the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case on Tuesday sought the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI)'s response on a plea filed by three accused seeking the permission to voluntarily undergo a lie detector test and brain mapping examination in order to "assist" the federal agency in its investigation.

Special judge Ajay Gupta was hearing a plea moved by accused Mangal Lal Bival, Dinesh Bival and Vikas Bival, through advocate AP Singh, who scheduled the matter for August 6.

According to the petitioners' submission, they were "voluntarily seeking to undergo the scientific test without any coercion to demonstrate their bona fides and assist the investigating agency in conducting a fair and transparent investigation". The plea also stated that the applicants have consistently main-

tained their innocence from the inception of the investigation and continue to assert that they have neither committed nor participated in the offences alleged against them."

They also sought to assist the investigating agency by voluntarily offering themselves for recognised scientific examination at any government-appointed Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL), so that the agency can explore every lawful investigative avenue.

The proceedings on Tuesday also marked a change in the presiding judge, with special judge Gupta designated to hear the paper leak case.

He replaced special judge Anu Grover Baliga, who was transferred on August 1 to a special NIA court to try terror cases. Two prosecutors have been assigned to the court by the Directorate of Prosecution. The case pertaining to the alleged leak of the NEET-UG 2026 examination paper.

SC wants fuel sale ban on uninsured vehicles

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Centre and the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) to evolve a pilot project to check whether uninsured vehicles could be denied fuel at petrol pumps, while also ordering a technology-driven enforcement mechanism to automatically identify and penalise such vehicles.

In a landmark bid to tackle the menace of uninsured vehicles and ensure timely compensation for road accident victims, a bench of Justice Sanjay Karol and Prashant Kumar Mishra issued a slew of directions, including integration of Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) cameras with insurance databases to generate automatic e-challans for uninsured vehicles, provision of handheld devices to traffic police for real-time verification of insurance status, enhancement of mandatory third-party insurance tenure for new vehicles, and expeditious disposal of old motor accident compensation cases.

Observing that nearly 56% of vehicles plying on Indian roads remain uninsured, the bench said the statutory safeguard of compensating road accident victims was often "delayed, if not defeated", forcing victims and their families into prolonged litigation. "The object behind mandatory insurance under Section 146 of the Motor Vehicles Act is not just that victims of road accidents are compensated, it is also that they are not drawn into prolonged litigation," it noted.

The court directed the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) and IRDAI to examine a pilot project under which fuel supply would be linked to a vehicle's insurance status. "In the absence thereof, the vehicle concerned must be refused fuel at petrol pumps until such time that valid insurance is obtained," ordered the bench, noting that the Ministry

Highlights of proposal

A pilot project under which uninsured vehicles could be denied fuel

Auto e-challans via ANPR cameras

Real-time insurance checks by traffic police

Strict enforcement of tougher penalties for uninsured vehicles

Four-year cover for new cars; six years for two-wheelers

Citizen portal to verify vehicle insurance

Barrier-less tolling pilot on select highways

Fast-track pre-March 2022 accident claims

of Petroleum and Natural Gas had, in principle, expressed no objection to the proposal. The bench underlined that such a mechanism would help identify uninsured and unregistered vehicles while making owners to maintain valid insurance. It suggested that the project could be implemented using ANPR cameras.

To strengthen enforcement, the court directed that ANPR cameras already deployed on highways and city roads for detecting traffic violations be integrated with the insurance Insurance Bureau database and the Vahan portal to enable automatic issuance of e-challans to uninsured vehicles. It also directed States to equip traffic police with handheld devices or mobile applications linked to these databases to verify insurance status on the spot and issue challans. The court further directed strict implementation of the proposed amendment to Section 196 of the Motor Vehicles Act, which prescribes steeper penalties for driving uninsured vehicles once notified by the Centre.

In a significant change affecting new vehicle buyers, the bench directed that the mandatory third-party insurance cover be enhanced from three years to four years for new private cars and from five years to six years for new

two-wheelers. The court said it was extending the period by one year despite IRDAI and the General Insurance Council recommending against such a move, holding that the measure was necessary in the interest of road safety.

The direction builds upon the Supreme Court's ruling in *S Rajasekaran Vs Union of India* (2018), which had mandated long-term third-party insurance at the time of registration of new vehicles.

The judgment also overhauls the structure of motor insurance policies. Accepting IRDAI's proposal, the court directed implementation of a uniform four-layer framework comprising a mandatory third-party policy, an optional legal liability cover for occupants and pillion riders, an optional personal accident cover for the owner, driver and occupants, and an optional own-damage cover.

With a view to ensure informed consumer choice, every purchaser of motor insurance—online or offline, will have to be provided with a standardised customer option form allowing them to opt into additional covers, along with a consumer-friendly information sheet explaining the mandatory and optional components of motor insurance. The court also directed IRDAI, in consultation with the General Insurance Coun-

cil and insurers, to formulate uniform policy wordings for the optional covers while allowing insurers flexibility in pricing and innovation.

The bench additionally directed insurance companies to prominently display the benefits of comprehensive motor insurance policies on their websites in an easy-to-understand format.

Concerned over delays in compensation cases, the court further revived earlier directions governing motor accident claims for accidents that occurred before March 31, 2022, when the Detailed Accident Report (DAR) regime became operational under the Central Motor Vehicles Rules.

Relying on a clutch of previous rulings, the bench directed State police to promptly file DARs along with all relevant documents before motor accident claims tribunals (MACTs) in pending pre-March 2022 cases and ensure production of witnesses to facilitate speedy disposal.

The court noted that more than half of MACT cases continue to remain pending for over four years and stressed that road safety forms an integral part of the right to life under Article 21.

The bench directed all stakeholders to comply with its directions and file affidavits by August 14, and listed the matter for monitoring compliance on August 18.

The directions came while disposing of an appeal filed by National Insurance Company Ltd against a Telangana High Court judgment awarding compensation to the family of a man who died in a 1996 road accident while travelling in his own Maruti 800 car.

The insurer had argued that the comprehensive insurance policy did not cover the owner's risk. Affirming the high court's view, the bench held that a comprehensive policy covered the owner travelling in the vehicle and declined to interfere, reiterating that courts should not adopt a hyper-technical approach in motor accident compensation matters.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Asaram doesn't need hospitalisation: SC

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court will take up the bail plea of self-styled godman Asaram Bapu in a rape case on Thursday after an independent medical board recommended that while he need not be monitored, he does not require hospitalisation. The Rajasthan High Court has granted 20-day parole to the 85-year-old Asaram, who is

lodged in Jodhpur Central Jail. He is serving life sentence in a 2013 sexual assault case.

SIT arrests key accused in the Andhra Pradesh liquor scam

HYDERABAD: The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Andhra Pradesh police probing the alleged multi-crore liquor scam during the previous YSR Congress government on Monday night arrested Eshwar Kiran Kumar Reddy,

one of the key accused, who has been absconding for the last two years, police said. An officer said Reddy was detained by immigration authorities at the Hyderabad airport after returning from India from Dubai.

'Ghajini', 'Lagaan' fame actor Pradeep Rawat dies at 74

MUMBAI: Actor Pradeep Rawat, known for his roles in 'Lagaan' and 'Ghajini', died on Tuesday after a battle with cancer. He was 74.



CP John

ROW ERUPTS OVER KERALA MINISTER'S WOMEN REMARK

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Transport Minister CP John drew flak on Tuesday for his remarks allegedly belittling women who avail free rides on state-run buses under the Priyadarshini scheme implemented by the UDF government in June.

Speaking at a state conference of the Kerala Bus Transport Association, a trade union body of private buses, in Palakkad on Monday, the minister said that he was astonished by the behaviour of women in Kerala when it comes to their choices in public health, education and transport.

"The behaviour that I don't understand is that a woman, who cannot afford a bus ticket and scrambles into the Priyadarshini buses for free rides, chooses to send her children to private schools which charge high fees," the minister said.

He clarified on Tuesday, saying he only spoke about the "state of poverty of women".

The opposition, however, slammed him. CPI leader Annie Raja said the minister must apologise. "His remarks amount to insulting women. The government continues to portray its schemes as some kind of generosity," she said.

CRPF officer kills two colleagues, shoots self

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SILCHAR: A Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) officer posted in Assam's Nagaon district on Tuesday allegedly killed two of his colleagues with a service rifle and later died by suicide, police said, adding that another jawan sustained gunshot injuries in the incident and was rushed for treatment.

According to police, the assistant sub-inspector, hailing from Andhra Pradesh, who was deployed at the main gate of CRPF's Katimari (34 Battalion), took an INSAS (Indian Small Arms System) rifle from the guard room and opened fire at sub-inspector Rannawal Singh Yadav, ASI Mane Govind Sripul and head constable Vishnu Prasad Baghel.

The incident took place at around 7:30 am.

POLICE ARE PROBING THE INCIDENT THAT TOOK PLACE IN ASSAM'S NAGAON DISTRICT

"Yadav and Baghel died on the spot, while Sripul sustained severe injuries and has been admitted to a local hospital," said Partha Pratim Das, the Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) of Nagaon. Later, the injured personnel was referred to Gauhati Medical College and Hospital, the officer said.

"The ASI later shot himself with the same rifle; however, the motive behind the incident is yet to be established," the SSP added. Police said they have launched an investigation to determine the circumstances that led to the firing.

SC bars mining in 10-km radius of wetland in HP, without Centre's nod

Abraham Thomas

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday held that no mining activity will be permitted within a 10-kilometre radius of a wetland conservation reserve in Himachal Pradesh without prior permission of the Union government.

The court further directed the Ministry of Environment Forests and Climate Change (MoEFCC) or the Standing Committee of National Board of Wildlife (SC-NBW) to inform it within a month about the wetland conservation reserves in the state.

In February 2024, the top court imposed the 10-kilometre radius bar on mining in the context of Asan wetland, a Ramsar site, situated in Uttarakhand. Based on this order, a public interest litigation was filed before the Himachal Pradesh high court to extend the same rule to wetland conservation reserves in Himachal Pradesh.

Ramsar sites are wetlands of international importance under the Ramsar Convention, an environmental treaty established in 1971 to conserve biodiversity, particularly waterfowl habitats.

The state of HP moved the top court seeking clarification as it stated that the 10-km regulation by the court was specific only to Asan wetland and cannot be mechanically applied to them.

Deciding the application, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Supta Kant said, "If a wetland conservation reserve is

found or identified in Himachal Pradesh, in that case, the direction issued by us on February 14, 2024 shall apply mutatis mutandis in case of Himachal Pradesh also."

The bench, also comprising justices Joymyalya Bagchi and V Mohana said that the direction is issued as the states of Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh form part of a contiguous Himalayan terrain, separated by a geographical line separating the two states.

The bench said, "If there is a wetland in Uttarakhand or Himachal Pradesh, only because of a demarcation line on paper, we cannot pass two different orders for the entire Himalayan terrain. It will be governed by the same rule unless you are able to show there is no wetland."

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Govt distances itself from Hasina presser

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NEW DELHI: The Indian government on Tuesday distanced itself from former Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina's plans to address a virtual news conference on August 5, saying it has no involvement in the event being organised by a private entity and does not endorse views that may be expressed at the forum.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal outlined the Indian side's position on the event to be addressed by Hasina at the Foreign Correspondents Club in New Delhi a day after a top aide of Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman told Indian high commissioner Dinesh Trivedi in Dhaka that the news conference could undermine bilateral relations.

"The interaction that you are referring to is being organised by a private media entity," Jaiswal told a regular media briefing while responding to a question about Hasina's planned news conference.

"The government has no involvement whatsoever in it. Neither does it endorse any views that may be expressed at the forum," he said. "We have no connection to it."

Jaiswal declined to comment in response to another question on Hasina's plans to return to Bangladesh from self-exile in India by December.

Hasina is expected to detail her plans for her homecoming at her first virtual interaction



Sheikh Hasina

BANGLADESH HAS WARNED MEDIA AGAINST AIRING SHEIKH HASINA'S PLANNED ADDRESS FROM INDIA

with the media in New Delhi in the evening on August 5. She will also "outline her vision for Bangladesh", according to the organisers of the event.

In a related development, Bangladeshi authorities on Tuesday referred to a ban imposed by the International Crimes Tribunal on the publication of Hasina's remarks in the Bangladeshi media and urged all TV channels, newspapers, online portals and social media platforms not to carry her comments and statements.

A statement issued by Bangladesh's Press Information Department in Dhaka noted that the tribunal had directed the information ministry, ICT department and Bangladesh Telecommunication Regulatory Commission to enforce the ban. It further pointed out that

the National Cyber Security Agency too had asked media organisations not to carry Hasina's comments.

The deposed 78-year-old former premier has lived in India since she fled Dhaka since the collapse of her government in August 2024 following weeks of violent protests led by student groups. She has said in recent interviews that she intends to go back home by December and surrender to the courts.

Bangladeshi officials have said Hasina, who has been given the death sentence by a tribunal for ordering a lethal crackdown on student protesters, will be arrested on arrival. The Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government has also sought Hasina's extradition, and the Indian side has said the request is being examined in line with legal and judicial processes.

On Monday, Humayun Kobi, adviser on foreign affairs to the Bangladesh PM, told Indian envoy Trivedi during a meeting in Dhaka that Hasina's planned news conference can underline the positive momentum in bilateral ties.

Kobi also said that Bangladesh expects India's cooperation in ensuring that no individual, including Hasina or members of organisations whose activities have been banned, can use Indian soil to deliver political statements or engage in activities "aimed at destabilising" Bangladesh, according to a statement from the foreign ministry in Dhaka.

PM Rahman invited to join Brics summit

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NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday confirmed that Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman has been invited to attend the upcoming Brics Summit in New Delhi in his capacity as the current chair of the Bimstec grouping, even as it pointed out a separate invitation was extended to him when he assumed office in February.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal provided details on the invitation sent to the Bangladesh PM for the Brics Summit against the backdrop of a campaign in sections of the Bangladeshi media that the move was a diplomatic slight as the invitation did not refer to him as the Prime Minister. "You would be aware that a formal invitation to the Bangladesh Prime Minister to visit India was extended when he assumed office in February 2026," Jaiswal told a regular media briefing while responding to a question on the matter.

"As far as the Brics Summit is concerned, India has separately extended an invitation (to Rahman) in his capacity as the current chair of Bimstec to attend the outreach session of the 18th Brics Summit, which will be held in New Delhi," he



Tarique Rahman

said. The invitation for the Brics Summit was extended in line with the standard practice followed within the grouping for inviting countries for the outreach sessions. "Other heads of regional groups have also been invited in a similar manner," Jaiswal said.

There is still no official word from the Bangladeshi side on whether Rahman will attend the Brics Summit, people familiar with the matter said. Rahman chose Malaysia and China as the destinations for his first foreign trip, breaking with the convention of Bangladesh's leaders usually travelling to India after assuming office.

Besides Rahman, India has invited the leaders of Bahrain, the chair of the Gulf Cooperation Council; Burundi, the chair of the African Union; the Philippines, the chair of Asean; and Uruguay, the chair of the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States (CELAC).

SC SEEKS SCHEME FOR EMPLOYING OUTBOARDED INJURED CADETS

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Centre to consider framing a scheme for military cadets who are boarded out of training academies due to injuries but are not eligible for benefits under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act because their disability is assessed at less than 40%.

Granting the Centre one month to come up with a proposal, a bench of justices BV Nagarathna and Manmohan stressed the need to support such cadets and their families.

"You have to see the plight of the parents seeing their children with arms amputated, wheelchair bound, nobody to look after them when they are gone," the bench told the Centre.

The court said cadets who are forced to leave military training after suffering injuries cannot be treated like "ordinary" students. "These young men have qualified in training and passed a competitive test to join as officers in the Army. It is an unfortunate thing they have to face in their lives," it observed.

Additional solicitor general N Venkataraman informed the bench that the RPwD Act already provides opportunities to cadets with benchmark disabilities but clarified that boarded-out cadets cannot be treated as ex-servicemen because they are not formally inducted into service.

274 fugitives brought back from 36 nations since 2019, says Centre

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NEW DELHI: India has brought back 274 fugitives from 36 countries since 2019, including suspects wanted in terrorism, organised crime, narco-terrorism and other serious offences, the government said on Tuesday, revealing that many of them were tracked abroad through satellite imagery, surveillance and digital footprints with the help of Intelligence Bureau (IB), Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), state police forces and other agencies.

"Operation Trishul" was launched to track the geo-location of fugitives. With INTERPOL's cooperation, the location of the criminals in hiding was established based on satellite, surveillance, and digital footprint. Although fugitives had changed their names or identities abroad, technology and profile-mapping still tracked them down," the government said in a statement.

Of the 274 fugitives brought back in the last seven years, 17 were wanted in terrorism and narco-terrorism cases, 42 in organised crime, gangsterism and extortion cases, and 53 booked in sexual offences cases, including under PoSxo Act, according to government records. The highest 70 fugitives were brought back in 2025 while at least 45 have been brought back till July this year.

Union home minister Amit Shah in a post on X said: "Regardless of which country they absconded to, India's new approach to national security has ensured the return of 274 criminals since 2019, compared with a mere four per year during the UPA regime."

GONE ARE THE DAYS WHEN CRIMINALS WERE ALLOWED TO SNEAK THROUGH THE GAPS IN THE SYSTEM, SAYS SHAH

Gone are the days when criminals were allowed to sneak through the gaps in the system, he said. "New India has addressed every gap in the old system through new laws, institutions, and global partnerships, weaving an unbreachable security net."

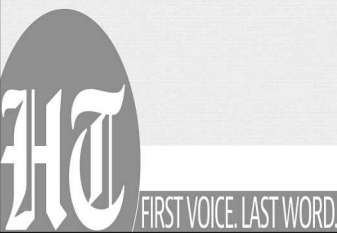
Officials in the security establishment said the number of fugitives being brought back to India is expected to rise further this year, driven by the Centre's war on drugs and the launch of a three-year roadmap for all agencies. "All agencies have prepared a list of narco-terrorist fugitives who must be brought back before 2029. The number will see a meteoric rise this year," an official said, asking not to be named, adding that one narco-terrorist has already been detained in a friendly country and his deportation details are being worked out.

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A quiz on the week's development.



SC ACQUITS TRIPLE
MURDER CONVICT
AFTER 22 YEARS,
FAULTS ORISSA HC

Ayesha Arvind
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Supreme Court on Tuesday acquitted a man who spent 22 years in prison in a triple murder case, holding that the evidence against him was "unreliable" and expressing concern that a procedural lapse by the Orissa HC had kept him behind bars for an additional decade.

Lamenting that "access to justice continues to elude the marginalised sections of society," a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran acquitted Arjun Jani, who was convicted of murder and sentenced to life imprisonment in 2006 in connection with a 2004 triple murder case. The court also directed the district administration and legal services authority to help rehabilitate and resettle him.

The bench criticised the Orissa High Court for dismissing Jani's appeal against his conviction on the ground of delay, saying the decision had cost him an additional 10 years in prison.

"We are deeply dismayed, and equally perturbed by the order which rejected an application seeking condonation of delay of 3157 days and as a consequence dismissed the 'jail memo of appeal' against the order of conviction under Section 302 of the IPC, with sentence imposed of life imprisonment where the convict had, at the time of the impugned order suffered incarceration of 12 years and now a further period of 10 years, a total of 22 years," the apex court said.

Jani was convicted in 2006 and sentenced to life imprisonment. On January 11, 2016, the High Court dismissed his appeal after refusing to condone a delay of 3,157 days in filing it. He subsequently approached the SC, which granted him bail in May and admitted his appeal.

The apex court said, "The trial court failed to properly assess the evidence, while the High Court remained a moot spectator by dismissing the appeal on procedural grounds," it said.

"Access to justice still eludes the marginalised sections of our society and especially those convicted and imprisoned from amongst them. As a result, Jani had ended up spending 22 years of his life in prison despite the absence of reliable evidence linking him to the crime," it added.

Heatwave, lightning added to
natural calamities list: Centre

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Heatwave and lightning have been included in the list of notified natural calamities under the operational guidelines for the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF) and National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF), the Union home ministry informed the Lok Sabha on Tuesday, adding that at least 20 heat stroke deaths have been reported in the country between March 1 and July 26 this year.

"The 16th Finance Commission, in its recommendations for the award period 2026-31, recommended inclusion of heatwaves and lightning in the list of notified natural calamities, considering the increasing frequency and intensity of extreme weather events arising from climate change," minister of state for home Nityanand Rai told the Lower House in response to a set of questions from fellow BJP MP Anoop Pradhan Valmiki.

Based on these recommendations, the ministry of home affairs has "included heatwaves and lightning in the list of notified natural calamities" under the operational guidelines for administration of the SDRF and NDRF for the award period 2026-31, Rai said.

The minister added that a policy framework for providing relief assistance through SDRF/NDRF is now in place.

Rai also informed that there were 4,853 heat stroke cases between March 1 and July 26, 2026, while the confirmed heat-stroke deaths were 20 in the country during the period.

Most heat stroke cases were reported from Telangana (915 cases), followed by West Bengal (733) and Chhattisgarh (660).

The current list of notified disasters has 12 entries: cyclone,

THE INCLUSION
WILL ENSURE
STATES CAN USE
THE SDRF FUND
FOR PROVIDING
RELIEF AND
ASSISTANCE TO
AFFECTED PEOPLE

drought, earthquake, fire, flood, tsunami, hailstorm, landslides, avalanches, cloudburst, pest attack, and frost and cold waves.

The latest inclusion will ensure states can use the SDRF fund for providing relief and assistance to people affected by heatwaves and lightning.

Welcoming the move, Anjal Prakash, a climate expert and an IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change) author, called it a significant policy shift.

"It's an important step, given India's rising exposure and fragmented response to it. By including these as notified calamities, states can now take central support for relief, which was previously hard to justify under the disaster finance tools," he said.

"The 16th finance commission has also cited an increasing frequency and intensity of extreme weather events due to climate change. This brings India's fiscal architecture closer to observed and projected risk, especially for urban and Agrarian population. Cities can also move away from ad-hoc solutions, to proper measures now," Prakash further said.

3 NCPI MPs SKIP
NDA PARTY MEET

NEW DELHI: Three NCPI MPs on Tuesday stayed away from the weekly NDA parliamentary party meeting but attended a lunch hosted by West Bengal chief minister Suvedu Adhikari at Banga Bhawan in New Delhi, amid signs of differences within the 20-member TMC rebel group.

The three MPs — Khalilur Rahman, Abu Taher Khan and Yusuf Pathan — also stayed away from the NDA's 'Mangal Milan' meeting on July 28. Rahman said, "We are not with the NDA, and neither are we going to the BJP, rest assured."

NCPI floor leader Sudip Bandyopadhyay also attended the Tuesday meeting. He could not attend the July 28 meeting. "I am one of the senior-most parliamentarians in the country. All are united in NCPI. It is a good experience," he said. However, the BJP declined to comment on the absence of three NCPI lawmakers.

ASSAM: AUTOPSY
CONFIRMS RAPE,
S.I.T FORMED

SILCHAR: A Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed to investigate the alleged rape and murder of 16-year-old girl in Assam's Hailakandi district in which three teenagers, including a minor, have been arrested so far, police said on Tuesday, adding that the autopsy report confirmed that the victim was raped before she was murdered.

"Post mortem examination suggested that the victim was raped," police said in a statement released on Tuesday.

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A quiz on the week's development.

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Sunday Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI
JANUARY 22, 2023

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himalach village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out

Natasha Rego



Ammar Reshi (right) is the author of the children's book Alice and Sparkle (above). Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

Ammar Reshi is not an author or illustrator, but he "wrote" Alice and Sparkle, a children's book which has sold over 900 copies since it was listed in Amazon in December. It features characters with typically crooked eyes and 12 fingers. Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

She's a lapsed Mormon and was briefly a DJ. Her partner Clarke Gayford is a fisherman. Her daughter here attended the UN General Assembly at three months. Last week she said, "You can be your own kind of leader — one who knows when it's time to go." Who?

The Ever Given blocked the Suez Canal in 2021. Now, the world's largest container ship is skipping India, whose main harbor in Mumbai is not deep enough. She's huge, she carries a lot, and she's almost as long as the Empire State Building is tall. Name?

Moharram Jah was born in France, gained his title in 1967, but his pricy purse in 1971, lived in Australia, lost his fortune, moved to Turkey, died, was laid in state at the Chavmahalla Palace in Hyderabad, and buried at the Mecca Masjid. Who was he?

Sachin Tendulkar was the first cricketer to score it in an ODI. Shubman Gill (left) is the youngest. In math, it is an abundant number. You want your total cholesterol to be below it. Give the number.

Which beauty queens featured on Harman Soodh's dress as she took her last walk as Miss Universe?

who also designed her pageant gown. It paid tribute to two former Miss Universes, from 1984 and 2000. Name the beauty queens.

Astronomers from Pune's GMRT and the phenomenon of gravitational lensing to detect a signal that originated from a distant galaxy some 8.4 billion years ago. A hat tip to Herta. What kind of signal?

— A former Minister Rishi Sunak uploaded a video

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Birth, death certificate bill cleared amid din

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Parliament on Tuesday approved the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which tightens regulations for delayed registration of birth and death, amid din and limited discussions in the House.

The bill, approved by the Lok Sabha last week, was cleared by the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday.

The bill proposes that any registration after one year of the event can be done only after an order of the judicial magistrate. Minister of state for home affairs Nityanand Rai said, "The government wants that every child born in the country should be registered and every death should also be registered. The country wants that anyone born in the country, it is important that he or she is registered. Anyone who has died cannot continue to remain in the voter lists to benefit some parties," he said.

Taking a jibe at the Congress, the minister said that in some states, there are governments that welcome such people to remain in voter lists, but it won't happen anymore.

Rai informed the House that 3.5 lakh (350,000) registration centres have been set up across the country for registration of births and deaths.

"In 2014, the total number of births registered in the country was 86.6%. In 2024, it rose to 99.1%. For deaths, in 2014, 72.5% of deaths were registered, while now it is 99.4%. The Congress cheated this country through birth and death registration," the minister alleged.

Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge said the House was not functioning properly and that there was only one way to run Parliament. "The Prime Minister and the Home Minister should come. We want discussion," he said.

Several NDA members favoured the bill, saying it was necessary, while Opposition members sought home minister's presence in the House. CPI(M) member AA Rahim, who was among those raising the demand for Shah's presence, referred to the deaths of more than 20 students due to NEET paper leak.

Oppn to press Shah on violence on students, raise donation issue

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: The Opposition has decided to sharpen its focus on two key demands—accountability from Union home minister Amit Shah over the use of pellet guns on students, and a debate on the alleged Ram Mandir donation theft—even as the government continued to push through bills amid repeated disruptions in Parliament.

At a meeting on Tuesday morning, Opposition leaders also agreed that if they got an opportunity to speak during debates on bills, they would use it to press for Shah's presence in the House. The stance reduces the chances of a return to normal proceedings and underscores the Opposition's determination to continue its protest.

Deputy leader of the Congress, Gaurav Gogoi, said on Tuesday, "It looks settled that the BJP want to shield home minister Amit Shah from any form of accountability in Parliament. He has been missing ever since Rahul Gandhi demanded his explanation. There does not seem to be any movement from the BJP to discuss the mismanagement of the Ayodhya Ram Mandir Trust."

Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha floor leader Derek O'Brien said, "All parties decided on Tuesday that we will seek home minister Amit Shah's accountability over the violence and use of pellet guns on students. We will also raise the Ram Mandir donation theft issue both inside and outside Parliament. If we get an opportunity to speak on a bill, we will use that to demand that Shah must come to the House."

Asked whether the government gained leverage by passing bills amid the din while the Opposition failed to register its objections, O'Brien said, "People will judge them. Bills should not be passed in the din. Every day the Opposition is registering its presence through its protests."

Oppn wants ISI bill to be sent to Parl standing panel

NEW DELHI: The Opposition parties insisted that the Indian Statistical Institute Bill, which allows greater control by the Centre, be sent to a standing committee for wider consultations, Congress leader Jairam Ram-
esh said in a post on X Tuesday.

The new bill proposes to repeal the Indian Statistical Institute Act, 1959 and replace the premier institution's society-based governance structure with a statutory framework centred on a government-accountable Board of Governors (BoG). HTc

The Opposition leaders staged protests outside Parliament over the Ram Mandir donation theft issue and repeatedly disrupted the House, demanding Shah's accountability. The latest demonstrations were backed firmly by smaller parties that are usually keen to participate in debates. "All big parties—the Congress, Samajwadi Party, Trinamool and Shiv Sena UBT—are in favour of continuing protests. We, the smaller parties, didn't say anything in the meeting on Tuesday morning, but we indirectly supported the stand of the Opposition," said NK Premachandran, RSP MP.

As protests erupted in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday morning, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla reminded lawmakers that Parliament is meant for discussion and dialogue. "This House is for dialogue. Only through that can we ensure the welfare of the people of the country. We will not be able to fulfil the people's expectations and aspirations through sloganeering and rhetoric."

Dip in employment generation under VB-G Ram G

Pallavi Singh
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NEW DELHI: Employment generation under the Centre's flagship rural jobs programme has slowed sharply during what is typically its busiest period of the year, with official data tabled in Parliament showing significantly fewer workdays generated than during the corresponding period last year.

An analysis of a reply tabled in the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday and a government release from July 25 last year showed that the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) and its successor, the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G), generated 7032 million persondays as of July 31. This is around 34% lower than the 1.07 billion persondays generated by July 21 last year, despite the current year's data covering an additional 10 days.

The first four months of the financial year typically account for a large share of annual employment generation under the programme. Last year, by July 21, 1.07 billion persondays—46.3% of the year's total 2.31 billion persondays—had already been generated.

Persondays refer to the total number of days of work performed by all workers combined. One person working for one day equals one personday.

The slowdown comes during the transition from MGNREGS to VB-G RAM G, which came into effect on July 1.

"The reason for this may be the fact that VB-G RAM G was started only on July 1 and there may be uncertainty about how the funds would work out. That may be one reason why workdays are lower," said Himanshu, associate professor of economics at the Centre for Economic Studies and Planning, Jawaharlal Nehru University.

He said the decline appears concentrated in states that have traditionally generated the largest share of employment under the scheme. "Most of the biggest states have shown lower number of days—the biggest shortfalls. They either were not prepared or are being hesitant as they have to fit the bill of 40% of the total cost," he said. The 60% of the cost will be funded by the Centre.

Among the states recording major shortfalls are Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh. Bihar generated 73.98 million persondays by July 31 this year compared with 223.22 million during the whole of FY2025-26. Madhya Pradesh generated 28.03 million persondays against 89.07 million, while Uttar Pradesh generated 38.59 million against 240.61 million. The slowdown has coincided with below-normal rainfall in several agrarian states.

"It is very distressing as some of the largest shortfalls are in bigger agrarian states which are probably suffering the worst of the rainfall deficits and therefore delayed sowing such as Bihar, Jharkhand, MP, etc. Demand must have increased year on year. This is a double whammy for the poor," Himanshu said.

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The Centre, however, maintained that the programme remains demand-driven and that employment is generated only when rural households seek work. A senior rural development ministry official said, "More than 99% of households demanding employment have been offered work under VB-G RAM G."

The ministry also said several states have notified up to 60 days of peak sowing and harvesting periods under the new law, which may have reduced demand for wage employment.



Data shows fewer workdays were generated than during the same period last year. HT

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Cities generating more sewage than they can treat, says Parl panel report

Soumya Chatterjee
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NEW DELHI: India's cities are generating far more sewage than they can treat, with an estimated 52,644 million litres per day (MLD) of sewage against an installed treatment capacity of 31,885 MLD, leaving a treatment gap of more than 20,700 MLD, a parliamentary standing committee report tabled on Tuesday said.

It warned that inadequate treatment capacity, weak operation and maintenance (O&M) and poor wastewater reuse continue to undermine urban sanitation. The committee has also flagged the issue of capacity often failing to translate into effective sanitation outcomes. The report said a third-party survey of over 1,000 plants revealed that only 51% of STPs comply with 2015 discharge standards and a mere 15% meet the more stringent 2019 norms.

It further noted that despite expansion of STPs of over 113.2 million in AMRUT cities are connected to sewer networks, while nearly 28.5 million depend on septicage-based sanitation systems. States including Madhya Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Odisha, Jharkhand and Bihar rely more on septicage systems than sewer networks, reflecting uneven sanitation infrastructure. The committee also flagged serious deficiencies in septicage-based sanitation, citing a study that found 60% of urban households depend on untrained masons instead of municipal guidance for septic tank construction, resulting in tanks that are often three to four times larger than prescribed standards.

The Standing Committee on Housing and Urban Affairs, in its

Solid waste management: SC seeks rules for compensation

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Centre to come out with "structured" guidelines for imposing compensation for violations under the Solid Waste Management Rules observing that the same cannot be left to the discretion of regulatory bodies, tribunals and courts.

In an attempt to make the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016 effective, a bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhya formulated eight guiding principles based on judicial precedents and said, "We direct the ministry of environment

forests and climate change (MoEFCC) to take into account the above-referred principles for determination and imposition of environmental compensation, as also the Rules that operate in the field, to formulate the necessary guidelines to be issued under Rule 17(2) of the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016."

The bench said, "...There must be a structured regime through which people will know with clarity and certainty, as to, for which type of environmental violation, what consequential punitive action will follow." ABRAHAM THOMAS

Review of Sewerage and Septage Coverage in Cities with special reference to interventions under AMRUT (Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation) and AMRUT 2.0, said that despite investments, urban wastewater management remains constrained by gaps across the sanitation chain, from collection and treatment to recycling and reuse.

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ENSURE ROADS REMAIN CLEAR, SC TELLS CIVIC BODIES

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed all states and Union territories to clear public spaces and roads of stray cattle and encroachments, warning civic authorities against inaction.

A bench of justices Abhishek Vinayak and N Mahadevan said, "There is total anarchy on the roads. Rules are not being followed. The state of affairs of encroachment of public land is not only shocking but alarming."

The court directed civic agencies to file action-taken reports against violations of building by-laws and ordered that all public areas across the country be kept free of stray animals in accordance with the law. The directions came while hearing a case from Tamil Nadu involving illegal construction. In March, the court expanded the matter by issuing notices to civic bodies in major state capitals, including Delhi, Lucknow, Jaipur, Chennai and Kolkata.

Senior advocate Ajit Kumar Sinha and amicus curiae Govind Jee informed the court that several states had either failed to file compliance reports or submitted inadequate responses.

The court also brought all states and UTs into the proceedings to assess the nationwide status of encroachments and stray cattle.

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FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

YOUR MONEY

The financial decision you should not delay

Postponing a Will can trigger disputes and administrative hurdles. Experts advise early estate planning, especially for substantial assets and family businesses

Lisa Pallavi Barbora
lisa@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: A smooth transfer of assets is not just about inheritance; it also saves time and gives peace of mind to those left behind. Yet many affluent Indian families continue to manage their finances without a valid Will.

Earlier this year, I Finance surveyed 1,218 people aged 40-60 across 20 Indian cities and found that 84.8% did not have a Will. Nearly 47% had never discussed Wills or estate planning.



PERSONAL FINANCE

Despite the small sample, the findings are revealing. Many assume succession will take care of itself and treat estate planning as a passive exercise. Yet nearly 31% of respondents reported experiencing some form of inheritance-related family dispute, suggesting the consequences are anything but passive.

Data from AasaanWill, a digital-first estate and succession planning platform with around 20,000 subscribers, shows first-time Will makers are typically between 42 and 55 years old.

Contrary to popular belief, drafting a Will is neither complicated nor cumbersome. Here is a quick guide to getting started.

Make a list

Start by listing everything you own. Record bank accounts with account numbers, balances and nominee details. Do the same for mutual funds, insurance policies, small savings, pension funds, EPF, fixed deposits and other financial or immovable assets. Also list outstanding loans from banks and finance companies.

This provides a clear picture of your net worth and makes it easier to decide how assets should be distributed. It also

saves family members from searching through emails and paperwork to identify assets. Once everything is documented, priorities are easier to act on.

Fix your nominees

A common misconception is that a nominee automatically becomes the owner of an asset. In most cases, nominees merely receive the asset and hold it on behalf of the legal heirs. Often a nominee may be a legal heir too, but to minimise confusion, clearly specify nominees for each asset individually and separately. Assuming everything will automatically pass to a spouse and children may seem reasonable, but that is not always how succession works. A clear succession plan ideally should have nominees plus a Will to define beneficiaries.

According to Sandeep Nerlekar, MD and founder, Terentia Consultants Pvt Ltd, an Estate Planning firm, "Writing a Will to safeguard wealth transfer is an easy task, unfortunately, it is also the last priority for many. In the absence of a Will assets are divided among Class I heirs which may include one's mother, wife and dependent children. Who gets how much is now not in one's control."

Nomination is a first step in operational clarity around succession. A Will defines beneficiaries according to a personal assessment rather than a mathematically fair division of assets.

"When it is assumed that the children will divide equally, it is usually the beginning of future disputes. Avoiding vague suppositions and instead having a clearly worded and well defined Will is what helps," says Vishnu Chundi, CEO, AasaanWill.

Write your Will

Once you have identified the assets and beneficiaries, draft the Will. It should clearly state who receives each asset, in what proportion, and who will carry out those instructions.

Deal with each asset individually. While financial assets can be divided in any proportion, physical assets are harder to split. Clear wording is essential to avoid procedural complications later. For example, when an adult who is the family's primary provider writes, "...all assets should go to my spouse or

my demise...", it leaves unanswered what happens if both spouses die in a common accident. In such cases, the family may need succession certificates, legal heir documents and multiple institutional approvals. A well-drafted Will can avoid much of this.

Once completed, the Will must be signed by the testator and two attesting witnesses. Without these signatures, it is not legally valid.

A Will does not need to be registered or probated at the time of drafting to be legally enforceable. Appointing an executor is optional but can be useful where multiple assets or income streams make administration more complex.

Anything that requires more than a Will?

"Anybody who has acquired certain assets should ideally define what will happen to those assets if something life threatening were to happen to them. While nominations are the easiest way to begin, nominees are not inheritors by default. A Will is what confirms who the assets devolve on to," says Nerlekar.

A simple Will may not be enough where estates are large, dominated by indivisible physical assets, involve disabled or neurologically impaired heirs, or include family businesses.

It's well known that Dhirubhai Ambani passed away suddenly without a formal, legally binding Will, ultimately causing a rift between his two sons over operational control of the group's businesses. More recently, after the sudden passing of industrialist Sanjay Kapur, a high-stakes legal battle worth tens of thousands of crores is ensuing between his widow from his second marriage and his children from his first marriage.

In such cases, experts recommend considering a Trust alongside a clearly worded Will.

Store it and inform someone

Once the Will is complete, ensure someone knows it exists.

"A Will hidden too well is almost as problematic as having no Will. Keep it in a secure but accessible location, keep a scanned copy and inform the Executor where it's stored," says Chundi.

While registration is not mandatory,

TABLE 1 WHO GETS TO CLAIM YOUR ASSETS?

Unless you document the claim in a Will or have a clear documented transfer of wealth, it can lie unclaimed for years



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF FINANCE, RBI
* INCLUDING PVT SECTOR BANKS AND FOREIGN BANKS

TABLE 2 LAYERS IN YOUR SUCCESSION PLAN



Chundi says it may provide additional evidentiary comfort where there is significant immovable property or a higher risk of disputes.

It's important that someone knows that the Will exists and if one fears disputes over the division of assets, registering the Will may help.

"A Will is one of the few financial decisions where the benefit is not fully enjoyed by the person making it — it is enjoyed by the family that does not have to suffer because it was missing. Yet, most people abandon the process for a

very human reason: its important, but not urgent," he says.

Procrastination is common because the costs of delaying estate planning often remain invisible until it is too late.

Nerlekar recalls that during the Covid pandemic, fear drove a surge in demand for succession planning. Prospective clients approached his firm in large numbers, creating a rush to put succession documents in place. That urgency has since faded. "Not planning means the family has to bear the cost of inaction given that inheritance and devolution is



COMMON MISTAKES THAT CREATE DISPUTES OR UNNECESSARY EFFORT

Assuming nomination is sufficient

A nominee is not a legal heir and doesn't automatically own the assets which are transferred. It is important to have a nominee as that creates an operational takeover of the assets from the product manufacturer. However, you need a Will to verify if the nominee is the inheritor as well.

No residuary clause

Suppose one buys a mutual fund, opens a bank account, or receives inherited property after signing the Will. If the Will covers only listed assets and lacks a clause such as "All assets not specifically mentioned here shall go to..." those assets may devolve through intestate succession. This is one of the most avoidable causes of extra paperwork.

Beneficiary also acting as witness

For the Will to be legally valid it needs to be attested by the testator and two other witnesses. The witnesses should be adults and preferably not direct beneficiaries. Indian law does not invalidate the entire Will for this reason, but it can potentially cause conflict and become problematic for the family.

Not reviewing the Will

Life stages evolve, as do assets. It is a healthy habit to review periodically and revise if needed. For example, if a beneficiary predeceases the testator and no substitute is named, that portion may fail and pass according to succession law rather than the testator's intention. If the Will is reviewed periodically, this change can be made in time.

Waiting for the perfect time

There is no perfect time to draft a Will. If you own assets and you have dependants, then now is the time to start planning the wealth transfer process. It helps to avoid disputes and also makes the transfer of assets a smooth and efficient process for family members. The cost of procrastination may be invisible and in the future, but it is a given.

WITH INPUTS FROM AASAANWILL

ILLUSTRATION: HUDROM BIKASH

triggered post one's lifetime," he says

Drafting a plan for wealth transfer requires one to face the finite terms of life. It's not the easiest thing to do and definitely not an action we may assign urgency to unless there is a life event which becomes a trigger. But uncertainty is a given and life threatening events don't knock for permission before they arrive. Precaution is always better than firefighting.

Lisa Pallavi Barbora is a freelance writer and author of Money & Her

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

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READ EVERY SUNDAY

{ OUR TAKE }

Adjudicating without sexism

Judges must undergo training to address their unconscious biases and gender stereotypes

Words matter. In a newspaper report, court judgement, or the actual legal statutes of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), words that describe a crime, the perpetrator, and the victim or survivor always reflect the bias — conscious, or otherwise — of the person uttering them. A committee led by former Supreme Court judge Justice Aniruddha Bose has addressed the pernicious impact of incorrect language in its recent report. The committee's genesis lies in the unsavoury remarks of an Allahabad high court bench ruling on a Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) case, last March. The top court stayed the high court order, took suo motu notice to revisit judicial practices in sexual offence cases, and set up the five-member panel under Justice Bose. The committee, after examining 125 trial court judgements, made a number of recommendations.

To wit: "Helpless woman/helpless female" can be replaced by the more neutral "complainant or survivor"; phrases like "It destroys the very soul of a helpless woman" and "She was enticed away (good faith)" can be replaced with "Crime caused severe trauma to the survivor" and "Accused lured/abducted victim by gaining trust", respectively. The report also exhorts the judiciary to avoid using religious and physiological references, or to speak of a woman's honour and/or shame. For instance, sentences like "where women are honoured, there the gods rejoice" and "X outraged the modesty of Y" point to a worldview where a woman's modesty, virginity/sexual conduct, and choice of clothes play a role in the commission of a crime against her. While that may well be the limited socio-cultural understanding that all women contend with daily, the courtroom must remain a site where their constitutional right to personhood, choice, life, liberty, and dignity are upheld, irrespective of what society thinks.

The report acknowledges that judicial sensitivity is an ongoing process. We have come a long way from the General Clauses Act of 1897 which included the female pronoun in the definition of "he". More recently, the Handbook on Combating Gender Stereotypes also listed harmful gender stereotypes, in particular those about women, in judicial decision-making and writing. But, it is incumbent upon judges to undergo training to continuously address their unconscious biases and gender stereotypes. By doing so, they ensure that their judgements are in a language that is respectful, neutral, and free from stereotypes. Their words, after all, protect and uphold constitutional values of all of us — man, woman, and transperson alike.

An unequal sparring in Indian wrestling

A Delhi court's acquittal of BJP leader and former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh in a sexual harassment case filed by women wrestlers shouldn't surprise anyone. From the very beginning, wrestlers appeared to be battling not just Singh but the system. Even the filing of the initial FIR needed the Supreme Court's intervention. A little later, curiously, a minor wrestler who had levelled allegations against Singh withdrew her complaint. With that case against him under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act (POCSO Act) being scrapped, Singh stayed out of jail. As for the other case, the hearing was plagued by adjournments and delays, and eventually ended with the court ruling that the prosecution did not prove the charges beyond a reasonable doubt.

Aside from the merits of the case — what women wrestlers have indicated they will appeal — what does this decision mean for the morale of women in wrestling and other sports across the country? For months, WFI has made life difficult for those who complained. Like it, many other sports bodies are run as fiefdoms, with money, muscle, and political influence coming together. In 2023, 16 of 30 national sports federations even lacked an Internal Complaints Committee. The wrestlers' protest at Jantar Mantar in 2023 changed things, forcing some national sports federations to make changes to their structure. But they remain opaque bodies controlled by a few.

Wrestling, like any other sport, is played according to a set of rules. The playing field, at most times, is fair. The messaging from this incident and the way it has played out doesn't sit well with that.

Evolved procurement key to defence drones' utility

Traditional procurement, slowed by bureaucratic hurdles and long timelines, isn't built for a landscape that moves quite fast

Conflicts across the world have seen an increase in the use of drones, not just larger uncrewed systems akin to fighter aircraft, but hundreds of small, lightweight systems deployed for a variety of purposes. For India, the aftermath of Operation Sindoor has translated directly into monetary commitment — emergency procurement of new systems, and a reported \$2-billion commitment towards further drone purchases. These are steps that will help make India's fleet more competitive. But the money is being spent through procurement processes designed to acquire platforms with a much longer shelf life than a tactical drone, and that mismatch is the real problem.

What sets the procurement of small, tactical drones apart from the acquisition of most other platforms is how fast they evolve. A drone that is bought today is likely to be obsolete in a few years. The drone industry is moving so fast that the time it takes to procure a platform is often longer than the time it takes to develop one. This is a challenge that India's current approach faces.

China's success in this space owes something to exactly this kind of close involvement between the armed forces, academia, and the drone industry.

The armed forces have already begun reorienting themselves to these

new realities faster than procurement practices have changed. New tactical formations such as Ashvi platoons have been embedded in every infantry battalion, and Bhairav light-combat battalions are being introduced specifically to absorb drone warfare at the unit level. The Army wants 30,000 drones in the field and a lakh personnel trained to operate them within a year. That kind of institutional urgency deserves a procurement system that moves at the same speed.

India's Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) and Defence Procurement Manual (DPM) have made some provisions that help streamline acquisitions and upgrades, which are steps in the right direction. However, they fall short because buyer-seller relationships remain transactional, with little room for iterative processes. Government tenders address the need to procure platforms; they do not cater to the potential future requirement for modifications and upgrades, whether in hardware or software.

A model built for this pace already exists, just not in defence procurement. It resembles the way enterprise software companies buy computers: Government tenders address the need to procure platforms; they do not cater to the potential future requirement for modifications and upgrades, whether in hardware or software.

The idea is to have a contract where the buyer and seller engage over a long period of time, beyond merely the initial order. Vendors commit to supplying a guaranteed minimum number of flight-ready drones over time, giving industry the demand

predictability it needs to invest and scale, something that is currently lacking. In exchange, vendors take on an ongoing service obligation: sustained R&D to stay ahead of evolving countermeasures. Both parties jointly project future requirements based on global trends and developments in the civilian market, and once this capability bracket is set, buyers commit upfront to future upgrades against that broad bracket — rather than a narrow, fixed list of specifications. That means when better sensors, electronic countermeasures, or autonomy features are developed, they can be folded in without the delays of an entirely new tender and contract.

This is not about outsourcing India's combat power to private vendors. It is about sharing the burden of staying current between the defence forces, who are the end-users, and industry, who will invariably have to meet their requirements.

None of this is free of cost. Locking into long-term vendor relationships will inevitably favour established players with the balance sheets to sustain them, at the expense of smaller

entrants. This is slightly contradictory to the DPM's own commitment to open competition. However, India's drone ecosystem already faces a version of this trade-off. Smaller manufacturers win a contract, deliver it, and then face an uncertain gap before the next one, unable to plan long-term R&D around unpredictable demand. A contract built around longer-term engagement doesn't eliminate that risk, but it converts a purely transactional relationship into a sustained one.

Despite its shortcomings, this model enables India to keep pace with an adversary whose electronic warfare unit adapts in eight weeks, not eight years.

Larger platforms will continue to have long-term utility in modern warfare. However, the part of the battle that relies on tactical drones will not stay still, and it is imperative that procurement practices evolve to keep pace.

Adya Mahavan is research analyst, The Takshashila Institution. The views expressed are personal



The idea is to have a contract where the buyer and seller engage over a long period of time, beyond merely the initial order.

The unbearable weight of learning, in school bags

Every weekday morning, children who still need help tying shoelaces walk to school bent under expedition-sized school bags. Inside are textbooks, notebooks, lunch boxes, water bottles, art supplies, workbooks, and an almanac. Adults join this procession, carrying the bags until children board the bus or enter the school gate.

This continues despite a court ruling, minority directions, and a government policy on school bags. The problem is familiar: Rules are announced ceremonially and circulated bureaucratically, while children cover the distance between policy and practice.

In May 2018, the Madras High Court confronted academic overloading in schools affiliated with the Central Board of Secondary Education. It directed authorities to ensure no homework for Classes 1 and 2, questioned subjects beyond the prescribed curriculum, and asked states and Union territories to ensure school bags did not exceed 10% of a child's body weight. The judgement's concern was larger than kilograms: Young children should not carry the adult anxiety of heavy bags meaning more education.

Later that year, the ministry of human resource development advised states and Union territories to regulate bag weight, prohibit homework in Classes 1 and 2, avoid additional books and prescribe class-wise limits. The Policy on School Bags 2020, prepared by an NCERT-led expert group, replaced the fixed national kilogram limits with a more sensible principle: A bag should generally remain within 10% of the child's body weight. That's what the Indian Academy of Pediatrics recommends.

The rulings and policy have provided a practical blueprint. Timetables should identify which books are required each day. Schools should provide drinking water, reduce the need for large bottles, and regularly monitor school bag weight. In primary classes, longer books for fewer subjects can reduce books carried. Teachers should consider the combined burden of textbooks, notebooks, lunch boxes and other materials.

Many schools continue to prescribe multiple subject notebooks, supplementary readers, practice books, art folders and diaries. Homework for the youngest children returns under the protection of "revision", "reinforcement", "grammar", or "family activity". Together, these habits create a system. The physical consequences deserve more than a shrug. A disproportionate load can affect posture and gait and contribute to shoulder, neck and back discomfort, especially when children climb several floors, commute long distances or sling bags over one shoulder.

Harm accumulates quietly; prevention, therefore, requires systems.

The intellectual burden may be worse, and it has a social inequity dimension. Homework often measures parental availability rather than a child's understanding. In affluent households, adults supervise projects, print pictures and improve presentation. In families where parents work long hours or have limited formal education, children may submit less polished work and be judged accordingly. An OECD analysis has found that socio-economically advantaged students spend more time on homework than disadvantaged students. Homework can, therefore, reproduce the inequalities it claims to overcome. India need not import a foreign model to

solve this problem. Textbooks can be divided by term. Workbooks can be integrated rather than multiplied. Schools can install labelled shelves or lockers.

Double-period timetables can reduce the subjects taught each day. Publishers should print lighter books, avoid glossy oversized folders, and disclose book weights. Digital communication can replace bulky almanacs, although screens must not become a route for endless assignments after school.

Every school should publish a book-specific weekly timetable and require teachers to follow it. A sample of bags should be weighed each term, with results shared with parents. Principals should review the total workload imposed collectively by all teachers, because no department considers its own notebook unnecessary.

New teachers should be briefed on homework and bag limits. Parents need a safe channel for complaints without fearing their child will be labelled troublesome.

Education departments and school boards must include compliance. Schools should publicly disclose their bag policy, homework policy and monitoring results. A rule without measurement becomes a suggestion; a suggestion without accountability becomes decoration.

There is also a moral question hidden inside this debate. Schools teach children about dignity, health, and scientific temper while requiring them to obey arrangements contradicting all three. A child who complains of pain may be told to become stronger; a parent who objects may be accused of protecting comfort to discipline. This reverses responsibility. Institutions, not children's spines, must adapt. Sensible limits and boundaries that authority should be able to enforce deserve protection and good systems remove pointless hardship.

Parents, too, must surrender to an illusion: A bag full of books is not evidence of an excellent school. Nor is an occupied child necessarily learning.

In senior school kids, competitive anxiety of parents makes idleness appear dangerous, encouraging families to buy extra guides and worksheets. But rest is not an empty time. Conversation and play are crucial for developing coordination and judgment; boredom nurtures imagination. A bedtime story may do more for literacy than another page of copied answers.

The heaviest object in a child's bag is often adult expectations. Schools fear appearing insufficiently rigorous; parents fear their children falling behind; publishers profit from glossy pages; and regulators confuse issuing instructions with enforcing them. The child, being the smallest participant, receives the burden.

A lighter school bag is an argument for education that is better organised, developmentally appropriate, and respectful of childhood. India has already written the prescription. What it lacks is the willingness to administer it. Tomorrow morning, millions of children will lift their bags again. The real test of policy is whether adults finally decide to lift some of the weight.

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ASTRID SCHOMAKER | EXECUTIVE SECRETARY, UN CONVENTION ON BIOLOGICAL DIVERSITY

Companies are not investing enough ... in analysing their biodiversity impacts, dependencies and risk

Ahead of talks in Nairobi next week

When broadcasting was committed to public good

A few years ago, visitors entering Bandrabhandi, a village in Hoshangabad district of Madhya Pradesh, were greeted by an unusual welcome. Painted across the village water tank were the words: *Kalyani Gram Bandrabhandi aapka swagat karta hai* (Kalyani Gram Bandrabhandi welcomes you). No government notification or official scheme had conferred the title. The villagers themselves had chosen the name.

Why? For years, Bandrabhandi lived under the shadow of malaria, spread by *Anopheles* mosquitoes. A weekly health programme series on Door-darshan — the community came together to fight the disease, under the guidance of the district malaria officer. When the village completed a malaria-free year, the villagers celebrated with a malaria awareness rally and renamed their village Kalyani Gram.

Kalyani was launched in 2002 by the ministry of health & family welfare in eight empowered action group (EAG) states to tackle communicable and non-communicable diseases, as well as other public health concerns. But how could a weekly TV programme become more than a broadcast?

An example of such enduring public ownership of broadcasting dates to the early decades after Independence. A variety of rice, popularised by All India Radio (AIR), came to be known as Radio Rice in Thanjavur district of Tamil Nadu. That was an era of one broadcaster and captive audience.

Decades later, in an India transformed by satellite television, digital media and changing media consumption, how could a weekly TV programme leave an even deeper imprint? The answer lies in the evolution of an idea — which transformed broadcasting from a medium of communication into a catalyst for community participation and social change.

In 1988, AIR launched a radio serial, *Jeevan Surathi*. It urged that the equally sensitive questions of marriage and marital relationships be explored as they entered the next stage of their lives.

Jeevan Surathi also opened the way for partnerships between AIR and development agencies — first with the Population Foundation of India for *Dehleez*, and later with Population Communications International for *Talkies*. Over the next decade, it expanded from adolescent relationships to HIV/AIDS, women's empowerment, and the environment, while growing in scale through partnerships with national and international organisations. The approach later informed

the BBC World Service Trust's landmark TV series, *Jasoos Vijay*.

In Lutsen, near Aligarh, discussions generated by *Tinka Tinka Sukh* led 184 community members to send AIR a collective letter, pledging neither to give nor accept dowry and to educate their daughters. The model also attracted international academic attention, with Everett Rogers, pioneer of the Diffusion of Innovations theory, and his colleagues documenting it as an important contribution to development communication.

This participatory methodology found its fullest expression in *Kalyani*. TV became the starting point for dialogue, participation, and collective action. The idea of organised community participation found expression through Kalyani Clubs. Each broadcast invited viewers to form local groups, discuss issues, undertake community initiatives and share their experiences, which then became part of subsequent programmes, encouraging other communities to do likewise.

Kalyani was extended from eight to 21 states, broadcast in 17 languages and 18 dialects, while nearly 2,500 Kalyani Clubs involving more than 83,000 volunteers emerged. The measure of success was not viewership but ownership. In some communities, anti-malarial tablets became known as Kalyani goli, newborn daughters were named Kalyani, and villages such as Bandrabhandi and Amlah adopted the name Kalyani Gram.

The programme's impact was measured not only in broadcasts but in the response it generated on the ground. That attracted international recognition: The WHO recognised Kalyani as one of the "15 top global innovations that advance the work of women's and children's health." It was described as "a revolution in television for communication, the best action programme going in the world." Its work in transforming the lives of people affected by HIV/AIDS was honoured with the UNAIDS Civil Society Award.

As broadcasting enters the age of AI and digital platforms, it faces twin challenges: harnessing unprecedented technological capabilities while achieving financial sustainability. Technology can personalise and multiply messages, but participation still depends on trust, dialogue and a sense of shared ownership. *Dehleez* to Kalyani is a journey that demonstrates that public value and financial sustainability need not be opposing goals. When broadcasting enters people's trust and engagement, financial sustainability can follow from public value.

Usha Bhasin is former additional director general, Prasar Bharati. The views expressed are personal

25 US states sue Trump admin over new tariffs

Tax amendment bill targets investment, manufacturing

Rajeev Jayaswal
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NEW DELHI: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday introduced the Taxation and Other Laws Amendment Bill, 2026 to make India a more attractive and predictable destination for global capital, strengthen domestic manufacturing and enhance ease of compliance with a range of tax incentives.

The finance minister introduced the bill in the Lok Sabha, seeking to amend three laws — the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income Tax Act, 2005, and the Finance Act, 2026. The bill also seeks to replace the Income Tax (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026.

In recent months, on account of foreign geopolitical developments and related disruptions in international trade and supply chains, the global economic landscape has undergone considerable uncertainty. Hence, a need has arisen to undertake certain immediate taxation measures with a view to mitigate the impact of external economic shocks, ensure stability in the domestic economy, and support key sectors affected by the prevailing global conditions... Sitharaman said, referring to the



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman speaks in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session. SANSAD TV

June 5 ordinance in a statement accompanying the bill.

The ordinance that was promulgated by the President of India on June 5 and was effective retrospectively from April 1, gave tax exemptions to eligible foreign investors on government securities (G-Secs). The objectives were to attract global capital from foreign institutional investors (FIIs), foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) and the Bank for International Settlements (BIS), deepen sovereign debt market, and boost liquidity in G-Secs. While the enactment of the bill will replace the ordinance, it will safeguard actions already taken under the provisions of the ordinance.

Speaking on the Taxation and

Other Laws Amendment (TOLA) Bill, a finance ministry official said it revolves around three themes — attracting foreign capital, encouraging Make in India and enhancing ease of doing business. Tax rules are being simplified so that foreign investment funds, cloud businesses and infrastructure investors to route more of their activity through the country. The common thread is to provide reliable policy and process certainty. Overseas players are often unsure whether operating in or through India will create an unexpected tax exposure. These

proposals give clear, stable and predictable tax treatment as well the process to get the desired tax treatment," he said asking not to be named.

The TOLA bill proposes to allow Indian data centres to be run on a leased basis rather than only under direct ownership, he said. "The result is a much larger and more flexible ecosystem of Indian data centres serving global cloud players. This reform is expected to help India build large AI data cities" and attract significant investment into them.

In order to encourage Make in India, especially for electronics (such as mobile phones, laptops, personal computers, tablets, servers and their key parts and accessories), the bill seeks to extend the period of tax benefit to the foreign companies supplying machinery and tooling to an Indian factory that makes electronics on its behalf from five years to 15 years, which is up to 20% of the value.

The change will benefit companies such as Apple.

In order to attract the rough diamond trade to India, the bill proposes a 15-year exemption. Since 2016, foreign diamond miners have been allowed to display rough diamonds in special zones in Mumbai and Surat

without being taxed merely for showing them. "To turn display into actual trade, the bill goes further and fully exempts the income of foreign diamond miners and the traders connected with them (i.e. sight holders, brokers, aggregators and auction houses), from selling rough diamonds in these zones, for a period of 15 years," he said. The definition of rough diamonds is also widened. The aim is to shift a meaningful share of the global rough diamond trade to India and to build a financing ecosystem around it, he added.

The bill proposes to remove the existing 2% presumptive tax on foreign companies that store electronic components in Indian bonded warehouses for their local contract manufacturers, he said.

Meanwhile, the Appropriation Bill, 2026 was passed in Lok Sabha by Voice vote amid opposition protest over alleged theft of donation at the Ram Temple and other issues. Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman introduced the Bill to replace an Ordinance which scrapped income tax with regard to foreign companies in government securities. The Bill seeks to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income Tax Act, 2005, and the Finance Act, 2027.

The BSE Sensex settled 0.3% lower, with the benchmarks showing a rare divergence for two consecutive days. On Monday, the Nifty closed 16% higher after rising 0.7% at the end of continuous trading at 315 p.m. IST.

"The 20-minute window when cash market trading stops makes traders blind as they cannot ascertain where the Nifty 50 will close. These two days under the new mechanism indicates that something needs to be done to fix the issues," said Rajesh Paliyvi, senior vice president and head of research at Axis Securities.

Tuesday's volatility is likely to

New auction system sparks Nifty volatility

Reuters

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India's benchmark index Nifty 50 saw sharp volatility for the second day as a new mechanism to determine the closing prices of stocks with futures and options triggered wild swings on the day when weekly derivative contracts expired.

The Nifty 50 was 0.6% lower at 24,614.9 points at 3:35 p.m. when closing prices for the day are set. Just a little earlier, at 3:15 p.m., when the closing auction window opened, the Nifty 50 was down 1.25% at 24,463.45 points.

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have had an impact on options premiums, triggering unexpected losses and gains for some traders, two analysts said.

The closing index value determines the settlement of millions of rupees of option contracts on the day of the derivative expiry, the analysts said, declining to be identified as they are not authorised to speak to the media.

Under the new closing auction mechanism, which began on Monday, a 20-minute auction is held from 3:15 p.m. IST to determine closing prices, replacing the earlier methodology that calculated closing levels based on the volume-weighted average price of trades during the final 30 minutes of trading.

HINDUSTAN MEDIA VENTURES POSTS ₹51 CR PROFIT IN Q1

Press Trust of India

feedback@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Hindustan Media Ventures Ltd (HMVL) on Tuesday reported a rise in consolidated profit after tax to ₹51.17 crore in the June quarter.

The company had posted a PAT of ₹10.24 crore in the April-June period a year ago, according to a regulatory filing by HMVL, the publisher of Hindi daily Hindustan.

Its revenue from operations was up 19.8% to ₹197.18 crore in the June quarter. It was ₹164.60 crore in the corresponding period a year ago.

Total expenses of HMVL were at ₹174.96 crore, up 8.46% in the June quarter.

HMVL's total income, which includes other income, was at ₹244.06 crore, up 27.56% in the first quarter of the current fiscal year.

On March 26, 2026, HMVL had decided to discontinue OTTplay business from March 31, 2026. The decision came due to long-term profitability concerns and high costs in the streaming market.

Hindustan media ventures is a subsidiary of HT Media Ltd, which is the publisher of Mint and The Hindustan Times.

DABUR SEEKS LEGAL ADVICE OVER FSSAI BAN ON '100%' CLAIMS

NEW DELHI: A day after FSSAI prohibited Dabur India from using misleading '100%' claims on several products, the homegrown FMCG major said it is "seeking legal advice" on the future course of action, hinting towards approaching a legal forum against the food regulator. Dabur stated that it had already initiated the transition of product labels, advertisements and website content referred to in the FSSAI order by removing the '100%' claim, with most changes either completed or currently underway.

The company said it is responding to the regulator and will continue to engage constructively with FSSAI to resolve the matter. However, the company also added, "Dabur is also seeking legal advice on the future course of action." On Monday, Food regulator FSSAI had said it has prohibited Dabur India from using many products such as honey, ghee, and edible oils using '100%' claims, saying that such labelling is against the law.

In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that it has issued a prohibition order to Dabur India Ltd over the sales of food products carrying misleading '100%' claims, including honey, apple cider vinegar, virgin coconut oil, sesame oil, cow ghee, coconut water, coconut milk and other such items.

Airtel Q1 profit rises 37% driven by strong India, Africa growth

Press Trust of India

feedback@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Bharti Airtel reported a 37.3% increase in profit after tax to ₹8,167 crore in the June quarter, driven by strong growth across India and Africa operations, the company said on Tuesday.

Bharti Airtel had posted a net profit of ₹5,948 crore attributable to the owners in the year-ago period.

Revenue from operations during the quarter increased 18.3% to ₹58,539 crore from ₹49,462.6 crore in the June quarter a year ago.

"Bharti Airtel reported consolidated quarterly revenues of ₹58,539 crore, up 18.4% year-on-year, and 5.7% quarter-on-quarter, supported by strong growth across India and Africa operations," the company statement said.

The telco recorded 12.5% year-

over-year (y-o-y) growth in customer base to 60.5 crore. Its subscriber base in India grew by 12.8% to 43.6 crore.

Airtel India's average revenue per user (ARPU) increased by 5.5% to ₹264 during the reported quarter compared to ₹250 a year ago. Revenues increased by 9.7% to ₹41,214 crore, driven by sustained portfolio premiumisation in mobile and strong momentum in Homes and Airtel Business, the company said.

"India Mobile achieved sequential growth of 3.8%, driven by continued portfolio mix improvement. Our postpaid strategy continues to deliver strong outcomes with the highest-ever customer additions of 1 million. They reached a customer base of 30 million. The smartphone data customer base grew by 21.1 million over the past year, marking a 7.5% y-o-y increase," Airtel said. Average data consumption per customer

customer additions and an improvement in ARPU.

"Focus on stronger portfolios led to strong net additions in the postpaid segment. We recorded the highest ever quarterly postpaid customer additions of 1 million, thereby reaching a customer base of 30 million. The smartphone data customer base grew by 21.1 million over the past year, marking a 7.5% y-o-y increase," Airtel said. Average data consumption per customer

on Bharti Airtel network in India grew by 27.7% to 34.4 GB in the June 2026 quarter from 26.9 GB a year ago.

Bharti Airtel's consolidated capex during the reported quarter stood at ₹13,386 crore, of which India capex accounted for ₹9,698 crore.

The company's net debt dropped by about 35% to ₹81,852 crore during the reported quarter from ₹1,25,489 crore a year ago.

Apple's recent sales figures from India, when presented in US dollars, are diminished by the rupee's decline. The Indian currency has dropped about 10% against the greenback since the start of last year.

As part of its India retail expansion, Apple opened a new store in the financial capital of Mumbai in February, taking its official shop count in the country to six. India's local sourcing requirements kept Apple away from opening its iconic stores in the South Asian nation for years.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

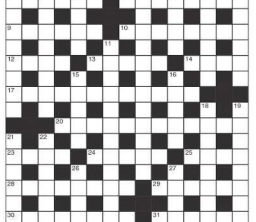
- 1 Unusual dish we longed for (6)
- 4 A bodybuilder or space traveller (8)
- 9 Healthy transport in decay (6)
- 10 A bloomer taking part in such a rebellion (8)
- 12 Outstanding (if not actually well done) (4)
- 13 Construct perpendicular (5)
- 14 Quiet group joined in conspiracy (4)
- 17 Advance from bank to bank? (8,4)
- 20 They're the 'so to go to the wall' (6,6)
- 23 Am all right though in a frenzy (4)
- 24 Making a cut key is critical (5)
- 25 A German may be followed by man in Turkey (4)
- 26 Weather patterns, Monday's soon building (8)
- 29 One in favour of half-day closing (6)
- 30 They may well drop in the centres (8)
- 31 Leaves the broken plates (6)

DOWN

- 1 Doctor wore drab clothes (8)
- 2 Out of town — and out of the country (8)
- 3 Language of half the universe (4)
- 5 Beaming they take the cash girl's change (12)
- 6 Watched (if heard) (4)
- 7 Gymnastics only seen outside in public (6)
- 8 To do so weakens one's spirit (6)
- 11 An original Christmas gift (12)
- 15 Silly down at melting point? (5)
- 16 Five hundred bent on a port (5)
- 18 It can make a man hate what is repellent to him (6)
- 19 Practically of an equally high standard (2,4,2)
- 21 Sailor joins a Scotsman on the roads (6)
- 22 Carpenter likely to become a union member? (6)
- 26 Payment at the door leading to a passage (4)
- 27 Release without charge (4)

PUZZLE 17556

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 Intended victim (6)
- 2 Sufferer (8)
- 3 Inferior substitute (6)
- 4 From the outset (3,5)
- 12 Rumour (4)
- 13 Company of witches (5)
- 14 To incline (4)
- 15 Following closely after (2,3,5)
- 20 Resources for achieving something (6,4)
- 23 Actor's part (4)
- 24 Lustrous (5)
- 25 Group of three (4)
- 26 A written guarantee (8)
- 29 Ignorable (6)
- 30 Put at risk (8)
- 31 Large lusked Arctic animal (6)

DOWN

- 1 Throw doubt upon (8)
- 2 Convincing (6)
- 3 Estimate value of (4)
- 4 Consoling feature in misfortune (6,4)
- 5 Rent (4)
- 7 Firmly established (6)
- 9 Virtually (2,4,2)
- 10 Those in authority (6,4,2)
- 11 Deaf (5)
- 16 Spacious (5)
- 18 Breed of retriever (8)
- 19 Virtually (2,4,2)
- 21 Read at random for pleasure (6)
- 22 Elaborately ornamented (6)
- 26 Inform of danger (6)
- 27 Hindu system of meditation (4)

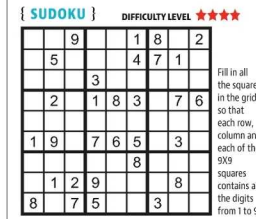
YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17555)



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- 3 UTILITY
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- 18 EMPTY

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DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE HIGH + LOW

WEDNESDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain

THURSDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain

FRIDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain

30°C / 22°C

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ALMANAC

Today in 1926

5th August 1926

5th August 1926

5th August 1926

5th August 1926

5th August 1926

5th August 1926

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 33°C / 24°C

Mumbai 31°C / 24°C

Kolkata 31°C / 26°C

Chennai 36°C / 28°C

Bangalore 30°C / 22°C

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Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Every Saturday, HT Brunch explores the people, ideas and cultural shifts behind the moments everyone is talking about.

EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

Injury woes: Why are India's pacers failing the fitness test?

Skinner Shubman Gill has a genuine reason to be upset but a more methodical approach could help the team

Sanjeev K Samyal
sanjeev.samyalk@htlive.com

MUMBAI: The World Test Championship cycle requires India to be at full strength for this month's two-Test series in Sri Lanka. In fifth position in the standings, the pressure is on captain Shubman Gill to secure maximum points and keep his team in the race for the final.

The India skipper will not be happy with the situation, though, as his bowling spearhead Jasprit Bumrah will not travel to Sri Lanka for the series starting on August 15. Bumrah needs more time to recover from the left knee issue he has been nursing since the T20 World Cup earlier this year. He also suffered an impact injury during the second ODI last year against England.

India are also without Harshit Rana and Nitish Kumar Reddy, who are out with hamstring and quadriceps injuries, respectively. Washington Sundar has also been ruled out of the first Test with a hamstring injury, while pacer Akash Deep is in the middle of a long layoff following stress reactions on his back.

Gill has a genuine reason to be upset. To get the job done, a captain needs all his first-choice players to be available. It affects the team's combination. This was one reason for India's debacle in the T20 series against Ireland and England and the ODI series defeat against England last month.

Gill had flagged a fitness crisis after the England series was marred by injuries. Speaking after the series declaration at Lord's, Gill highlighted that at least five players from India's original to-appear squad did not feature in the final match. "You look at the first squad we announced, at least five of the players did not play today," Gill said. "When one player gets injured, you have to play a different combination. If two are injured, you play a different combination. I think if a player is missing in every match (due to injury), somewhere we are missing a trick."

The injury list is not restricted to the five mentioned names. Several key players have faced fitness issues since the turn of the year. All-rounder Hardik Pandya has not played since the IPL first match in March. Then a quadriceps strain during a run during the BCCI's Centre of Excellence has kept him out. In between, Gill himself has battled a nagging neck problem. Varun Chakravarty sustained a Grade 2 hamstring tear during the third T20 against England. He missed the entire five-match T20 series against Zimbabwe.

Former India strength and conditioning coach Ranji Srinivasan understands captain Gill's frustration. "This is nothing new, I'm sure you all know this has been happening for the last few years. What we need to see is what trigger these injuries occur over time. And one of the things you need to ponder is the exercise pattern. The choice of exercise. The recovery protocols. The nutrition protocol."

Physio Ashish Kaushik, who was with the NCA and India team from 2009 to 2021, said: "I don't think we are testing enough and this is something that I was really pushing very hard for. You know the data needs to be collected. Since 2008-09 we've been collecting a ton of data but nobody knows what we've not published any papers. We've not done enough with that data to understand our athletes better."

Gill's statement also points out the role of the team support staff and the sports science department at BCCI's Centre of Excellence, where the cricketers undergo injury recovery and rehabilitation. "Load management is not just about numbers; it's about being very specialised to an individual athlete," said Srinivasan, who was the India team's SSC which won the 2011 ICC ODI World Cup and the 2013 ICC Champions Trophy. "Crunching numbers and giving the data needs to be collected. Since 2008-09 we've been collecting a ton of data but nobody knows what we've not published any papers. We've not done enough with that data to understand our athletes better."

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Injuries plague Indian pacers

JASPRIT BUMRAH

Bumrah's injury history has revolved around his back. After a fractured thumb in 2018 and a lower-back stress fracture in 2019, the problem resurfaced in 2022, costing him the Asia Cup and T20 World Cup participation. He underwent back surgery in March 2023 before returning later that year, with workload remaining an ongoing concern.

MOHAMMED SHAMI

Shami braved pain to play the ODI World Cup in 2015 before undergoing surgery in his left knee and going into rehab for 10 months. He stayed available until the 2023 ODI World Cup despite carrying ankle pain throughout the tournament. The injury was diagnosed as a serious Achilles tendon problem, leading to surgery in London in early 2024. He missed IPL 2024 and spent months in rehabilitation before gradually returning to competitive cricket.

AKASH DEEP

Akash Deep's biggest interruptions have been hamstring and groin-related issues during domestic and international cricket. While none required major surgery, repeated soft-tissue injuries have interrupted momentum and delayed extended runs in India's Test side, leading to careful workload monitoring by the BCCI medical staff. He sat out the 2026 IPL due to lower back stress reaction.

JASPRIT BUMRAH

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Jasprit Bumrah to young tearaways, injuries to pacers have repeatedly set the Indian team back. A look at the fitness woes as the team heads to Sri Lanka for a Test series

PRASIDH KRISHNA

The tall pacer's career has been punctuated by stress-related injuries. A lumbar stress fracture ruled him out for much of 2022-23 before surgery and lengthy rehabilitation. He returned in late 2023 but subsequent quadriceps and workload-related issues needed careful management, affecting continuity despite impressive pace.

HARSHIT RANA

Rana's rapid rise has been accompanied by periodic hamstring and muscular issues associated with high workloads. After undergoing knee surgery in February, recurring soft-tissue injuries have required rehabilitation and intermittent breaks, the latest at the cost of the ODI and T20I series against England because of a hamstring injury.

MAYANK YADAV

Mayank's career has been repeatedly interrupted by injuries despite his great pace. He suffered side and abdominal strains during IPL 2024, and then a significant back injury that needed surgery and kept him out of most of IPL 2025. After lengthy rehabilitation, he returned in 2026 with managed workloads as India monitor his fitness.

UMRAN MALIK

Umrans early rise was halted by a illness and injury. After being ruled out of the 2022 IPL, he battled illness and hip-related problems through 2024, missing large parts of the domestic season. He was signed for IPL 2025 but was ruled out before the tournament while continuing rehabilitation, returning to full fitness only ahead of the 2026 season.

league basis.

"It becomes difficult when you come to the ground in the morning and you come to know a player has a niggle, then it's almost like do you want to take a chance?" Gill had said. "Some player is 80% fit, you are playing with five bowlers and if this player comes out after bowling five overs, then who will bowl? This is difficult. So as a group we need to improve our fitness and all these things."

Srinivasan said with right and timely preparation the fitness concerns of the team can be addressed.

South Africa's conditions will offer a different challenge because the grounds are harder, bigger, and the pitches will have bounce.

The key players are going to be fast bowlers. Like at the last ODI World Cup played in South Africa, in 2023, where Jasprit Bumrah, Zaheer Khan and Ashish Nehra proved their fitness throughout the one and half month long event. Srinath and Zaheer played 11 games each and Nehra nine games.

Srinivasan said the key is to understand that one size doesn't fit all. "You have to go according to the player's nature because they know their body best. Rather than just working on strength or power, you need to train like a cricketer. What a fast bowler needs is different from what a batsman, spinner, or wicket-keeper needs."

Outer Delhi wins after Super Over

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Delhi Premier League 2026 witnessed its first super over of the season as Outer Delhi Warriors edged New Delhi Tigers in a thrilling contest in the first match of the day at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

In the first of a two-day clash, New Delhi Tigers posted a competitive 156/5 after recovering from an early wobble. Reduced to 37/2 before a rain interruption, the Tigers found stability through captain Himmat Singh and Lakshay Sharma, who stitched together a brilliant 101-run partnership.

Himmat led the charge with a blistering 61 off just 25 deliveries, smashing five sixes and four boundaries, while Lakshay anchored the innings with an unbeaten 82 off 41 balls. Siddhant Sharma was the pick of the Warriors' bowlers with figures of 2/25.

Chasing 157, Outer Delhi Warriors appeared in trouble at 80/4 before Monu Shukla delivered a breathtaking counterattack. His explosive 45 off just 17 balls reversed the course and brought the equation down to nine runs from the final over.

The closing moments produced high drama as a no-ball, a crucial run-out and a bizarre final-ball dismissal sealed the scores level. Himmat Singh's fumble at



Monu Shukla. OODA

mid-off accidentally ricocheted onto the stumps at the non-striker's end, catching the batter short and forcing the tournament's first super over.

Battling first in the decider, the Warriors piled on 20 runs, with Monu once again providing the fireworks. Chasing 21, Himmat gave the Tigers hope by launching the opening delivery for six but fell off the very next ball. Hritik Shokeen was dismissed on the following delivery, ending the chase as sealing a thrilling super over victory for Outer Delhi Warriors.

Talking about his mindset during the high-pressure chase, Shukla added, "I was happy with the way I batted. The plan was to play positively and take the game deep. We felt we could have finished the chase without a super over, but once it went in there, we stayed confident and backed ourselves."

The one thing you never lose is hope, says Coyle

Dhiman Sarkar
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KOLKATA: Jamshedpur FC were in contention for the 2025-26 ISL title till the last round. In a season where uncertainty was the only certainty, one that kicked off with resignations from the league's mercurial Indian captain, Jamshedpur FC were constant in their endeavour to ensure that football was not interrupted.

They had even signed head coach Owen Coyle on a two-season contract last January after Khalid Jamil left to take charge of the India men's team in 2025. Understandable therefore that Coyle would be left blindsided by last week's decision to disband the first team.

"I didn't see this coming," Coyle told HT over the phone from his home in Ribbles Valley, Lancashire. "But in football, the one thing you never lose is hope," said the coach who has been in charge of teams in Premier League and in Major League Soccer.

Since the decision to disband a first in the ISL, which began in 2014 – former India captain Sunil Chhetri and current international Sandesh Jhingan have asked The Tata Group, the club's owners, to reconsider. Rahul Bhoke, Nikhil Poojary and Bengaluru FC owner Parth Jindal



Owen Coyle. ISL

have said on social media they were disappointed with the club's decision. Jamshedpur FC's players have also appealed for a rethink and a protest march was organised by supporters in Jamshedpur on Monday. "The support Jamshedpur FC received from the football fraternity shows the esteem in which it is held," said Coyle. "Right now, my thoughts are with everyone at the club and the fans."

The club's decision stems from shareholders believing it is not viable to take part in ISL, as it stands, Jamshedpur FC have told AIFC. The club has said it will continue to invest in grassroots. They are playing in this Durand Cup.

Jamshedpur FC's infrastructure

was one reason why Coyle had joined after taking Chennaiyin FC from the bottom to the mid-table in 2019-20. "Some of the clubs have to rent grounds and are only allotted a certain amount of time," he had told HT in 2020, referring to Jamshedpur FC having their own training pitch.

In charge for the second time, having won the ISL league shield in 2021-22 which gave Jamshedpur FC the right to represent India in Asia, Coyle, 60, said he was driving to London to "watch a game when Mukul called. I couldn't take it and was told about it when I called back."

Mukul is Mukul Choudhary, CEO, Jamshedpur FC, who has nearly two decades' experience of running top football clubs in India. 2025 was the year of uncertainty in India's top league. The Supreme Court's approval of the new constitution of AIFC came in September. By then, the AIFC's commercial partners had ended his shock retirement from the heart of our project. And players deemed cast-offs."

Neeraj to compete in Lausanne DL

NEW DELHI: Neeraj Chopra will compete in the Lausanne Diamond League on Aug 21 against a star-studded men's javelin field also featuring recently crowned CWG champion Ramesh Pathange of Sri Lanka. Five from Glasgow CWG will compete. Chopra will face Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan, reigning world champion Neeraj Chopra of India and Tobi Amos of Tobago, former world champion Anderson Peters of Grenada and former Olympic champion Thomas Röhler of Germany apart from Pathange.

Stokes reveals coaching ambition

LONDON: Ben Stokes has revealed his ambition to coach England in the future, but ruled out any chance of ending his shock retirement from international cricket. "I'm doing my level three coaching now while I'm still playing, but I want to do it in the long term," he said. "I'm not playing anymore, I'd love to be able to have all that stuff signed off and done." Stokes said, "I know what I want to do in terms of staying within the game, which is to be a coach. And would I love to be coach of England one day? Absolutely."



Judo gold medalist Asmita Dey at IGI Airport in New Delhi. PTI

Took loans for my training abroad: Asmita

Avishkek Roy
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NEW DELHI: Asmita Dey's judo gold at the Glasgow CWG was the breakthrough India had been waiting for years. The 2026 CWG marked the fifth time the martial art has featured at the Games, starting with 1990 Auckland, but India had never won gold until now. Harsh Singh added a second judo gold as India finished with four medals.

Triprura girl Asmita, whose historic feat in the women's 48kg ended India's long wait for a CWG judo gold, has chased her dream overseas training from a modest background and facing financial hardship. She took loans to fund her overseas training without the knowledge of her family. "It has been a very tough journey, but it did not break my resolve. I am so passionate about this sport," says Asmita. Her biggest supporter was her father, who passed away last year. Despite the family's meagre means, Arjun Dey, a cycle mechanic, encouraged his daughter to continue in the sport.

"I am the youngest of three siblings. It was difficult for my father to run a family of five, but he was always there as my support. Financially, it was tough to continue in judo. I don't know how I managed," says the 23-year-old. Asmita, who trains at the Sports Authority of India (SAI) centre in Bhopal, says she has been funding her overseas training camps and competitions.

"Have taken loans not once but several times to fund my training in Germany and France. In India, finding good sparring partners is difficult, so you must go abroad to improve. I took a loan of ₹5 lakh and went for a camp in Germany. This year before the CWG, I have also been taking smaller loans for training abroad. I did not inform my family about the loans because they would have got worried."

She started judo when she was 14 and trained in a judo centre before moving to the Tripura

Sports School in Agartala. A breakthrough came when she was taken into the SAI NCOE in Bhopal, where she trained

Tech-based training powering Indian hockey teams forward

Sandeep Sikdar

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NEW DELHI: The hockey season is heating up. The Indian men fine-tuned their skills at the FIH Pro League in Europe in June, building up to the World Cup. The Salima Tete-led women won the Nations Cup in New Zealand.

The bigger tests lie ahead, the World Cup this month and the Asian Games in September-October. With just a fortnight separating the two mega events, the team managements are trying to build teams with robust athletes to help them excel at both the competitions without any dip in performance. This is where the role of sports science comes in.

For decades, Indian hockey was celebrated for its breathtaking stickwork, flair, and intuitive genius. But in the relentless ecosystem of modern hockey — defined by 15-minute quarters, rolling substitutions and hyper-aggressive pressing — flair alone is no longer enough.

To survive and dominate, India's national teams have re-engineered how they build athletes. Through an exhaustive, technology-driven integration of sports science, both the men's and women's programmes have shifted from reactive recovery to predictive, precision-engineered athletic performance.

The introduction of advanced data analytics into Indian hockey started with human connection. When Wayne Lombard, head of athletic performance for the women's hockey team returned to the role in January, he knew that data would be useless.

"My first job wasn't actually about VO2 max numbers or force plate data, it was about people," Lombard recalls. "It was about sitting down with the players and the coaching staff and earning their buy-in. Helping them understand that the physical side of the game is every bit as important as the technical and tactical side."

This cultural shift required moving away from a traditional "one-size-fits-all" coaching mentality. The modern setup introduced individualisation. Alan Tan, scientific advisor of the Indian men's team, notes that while players' intellectual interest



India women's hockey team during a training session.

in the data varies, the collective buy-in is absolute.

"There are players who have a healthy curiosity, such as Hardik (Singh), who would like to go further in depth after a brief of our objective has been given," Tan explains. "Other players are okay just being told what they need to accomplish."

The target is identical: eliminating what Lombard calls "energy leaks" — the subtle physiological asymmetries or conditioning deficits that hold an athlete back from their true ceiling.

The measuring process

For years, the multi-stage fitness test — the Yo-Yo test — was the absolute yardstick of athletic endurance in Indian sports. While it provided an excellent historical baseline, the hockey programmes have transitioned to more precise testing protocols to calculate maximal aerobic speed (MAS).

The women's team has adopted the 30x15 intermittent fitness test, where athletes run for 30 seconds, rest for 15, and progress across a 40m grid with speeds increasing by 0.5kph each stage. The difference comes down to prescriptive accuracy. Because hockey requires sustained high-

velocity efforts over longer shuttles than football or cricket, the 30x15 test allows Lombard to programme individual running intensities with pinpoint accuracy.

The results speak for themselves — when the women's team ran their first 30x15 test, they averaged a score around 18-18.5. Within months of structured, MAS-driven programme, that squad average climbed to a formidable 19-19.7.

The men's team utilises a dual approach, pairing the Yo-Yo IRT2 with a grueling 16x6 shuttle (approx 19.44m) test covering a distance of 1.463km. The Yo-Yo is an intermittent test that reflects the stop-start nature of our game," says Tan. "The baseline test gives us each player's MAS which can easily be converted into a VO2 Max."

The tech stack

Hockey is brutally punishing on soft tissues, knees and lower backs. To combat this, India uses an elite diagnostic tech suite designed to catch structural flaws before they manifest as tears or strains on the pitch.

Force plates measure ground reaction forces with precision, capturing how much force an

athlete generates over milliseconds. Tan uses this data to dissect peak force, the Rate of Force Development (RFD) and the specific loading mechanics an athlete uses when planting or changing direction.

To test muscle groups in highly specific hockey positions — such as the deep crouch of a defender or the rotational torque of a drag-flicker — the teams rely on fixed frame and handheld VALD systems. These isolate muscle groups (like the groin and hamstring) to look for structural deficits.

This data feeds directly into a comprehensive injury risk profiling system. If an athlete reveals a 15% strength asymmetry between their left and right hamstring during a weekly frame squeeze, they are immediately flagged. The intervention becomes preventative, altering their weight-room volume before an acute injury can sideline them.

Micromanaging with GPS

During a training session or match, the most critical weapon in the sports scientist's arsenal is the small GPS tracker tucked into the back of a player's vest. This unit registers every acceleration, deceleration, total distance cov-

ered, and high-intensity running (HIR) metre.

The weekly schedule is divided into specific "red sessions" (high-intensity zones). The sports science team sets hard thresholds for the day. For instance, strikers and midfielders might be tasked with hitting 1,000 high-speed metres in a session.

If a player falls short due to the tactical flow of a scrimmage, they don't simply head to the locker room. Instead, the GPS data triggers immediate, post-session running "top-ups" to ensure their physical load matches the periodisation model.

External load is only half the equation. Tan balances these GPS metrics against internal and subjective stressors. "Load comes in various forms," Tan says. "It can be categorised into internal (heart rate, blood lactate), external (force, distance, velocity), subjective (rate of perceived exertion), and objective (weight, power output). It is important to understand how these loads interact... Other unaccounted-for loads could include media, meetings, travel, and non-physical loads like emotion or stress."

This meticulous collection of numbers serves a pragmatic purpose: to empower coaches and medical staff to make better decisions. Annual medical screenings, comprehensive blood panels, and daily hydration testing ensure that nutritional deficiencies — like dropping iron stores or climbing inflammatory markers — are corrected weeks before a physical dip occurs on TV.

Whether it is deploying edge-case sports science research like pickle juice to halt neural cramping during late-game moments in tournament play, or scaling up an injured player's workload at a steady, data-backed rate to build long-term structural resilience, India's hockey teams are no longer operating on guesswork.

By embracing management legend Peter Drucker's core philosophy — "You can't manage what you can't measure" — the Indian men's and women's hockey programmes have transformed data into a collective competitive advantage. They have shifted from merely hoping to compete to a power built to contend.

Sindhu seeded ninth, Sat-Chi are 5th

PV Sindhu was seeded ninth in women's singles, while the doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty has been handed the fifth seeding for the upcoming BWF World Championships to be played at the Indira Gandhi Stadium from August 17-23.

India have two entries each in

all the five categories of the championships with at least one seeded entry in four. Lakshya Sen has been seeded 14th and the mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto are seeded 15th. Men's singles world champion Shi Yuqi of China and South Korea's women's singles star An Se Young are the top seeds in their

respective categories. Women's singles world champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan is seeded second while the third and fourth spots have gone to Wang Zhi Yi and Chen Yufei of China.

The draw for the championships will take place here on Wednesday.

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